

The Devil's Advocate and the Reluctant Speaker

Speaking – this biologically endowed capacity – is the hallmark of human intelligence. Although humans with various impairments can still fare well with soundless communication, thanks to the advent of the human invention of written symbols, text, and sign languages, speaking with sound from the vocal cord undeniably represents a remarkable achievement of human evolution.

Despite this unique human capacity, speaking is far from being a mere biological phenomenon. When looked at from the perspective of brain science, speaking is an outer manifestation of our inner brain connectivity. When looked at from a psychological perspective, speaking is a function of our immense mental world. When looked at from the perspective of a social function, speaking is a human communicative act. When looked at from political, legal, and other systems, speaking is the means to achieve our greater ambitions. As complex and vast as it is, for most people, the sound of speaking is, without exaggeration, the sound of life.

Relevant to this chapter is speaking's role in learning and education. Speaking obviously has much to do with human learning and education. From learning how to utter words, to how to count, to ask and answer questions in class, and all the way to how to express thoughts and advance positions in public, speaking is generally involved in all aspects of learning. To the extent that education is delivered face to face (or even in today's online style) to students in school, speaking in teaching and learning is the primary means to achieve educational ends.

However, available observations and research indicate that the role of speaking differs considerably from individual learner to individual learner.¹ And individual variation, as it turns out, is not solely explained by the differences in individual learners' temperaments (or associated later personality traits), a factor thought of as more genetically determined. There

is evidence that the cultural values and norms of learners matter more crucially.²

The West and East Asia offer a telling case in point. Surely, we observe that East Asian learners are quiet and reluctant to speak in class, whereas Western learners are more talkative and eager to express themselves,³ frequently even turning into devil's advocates. It is unquestionable that there are expressive and even pugnacious learners in East Asia, and likewise, quiet and timid learners in the West. Therefore, any attempt to take the observation of the quiet Asian learner or the expressive Western learner to fit any random individual learner in any place is doomed and cause for intellectual obscurity. Nevertheless, the preponderance of research evidence shows that there are more quiet East Asian learners than Western learners. Moreover, this oft-noted characteristic transcends time and space; that is, it is seen regardless of when the observations were made, and either in Asia or among the East Asian diaspora across the world.⁴ With this research evidence in mind, I argue that it is not very helpful to be stuck on the irritation caused by the stereotypical view of the quiet Asian learner. A more productive effort is to try to understand *why* East Asian learners tend to be reluctant to speak in class and why Western students are characteristically eager to self-express. To my mind, it is even more beneficial to analyze how speaking – or, for that matter, not speaking – serves learners from different cultural backgrounds. In what follows, I intend to review Western and East Asian traditions regarding speaking and not speaking, and speaking styles; I then discuss Western and East Asian learners.

LONG WESTERN TRADITION OF VERBAL ELOQUENCE

Speaking in the West is a highly regarded skill. This high regard for speaking dates back to the long political, religious, and intellectual tradition of the West. Four emphases are particularly noteworthy: speaking as distinct personal quality, as a right, as a leadership trait, and as art.

Speaking as Distinct Personal Quality

Speaking in the West is regarded as a personal quality, an expression of self.⁵ It signals a person's individuality and distinctness (as well as well-being⁶). Throughout history, many individuals achieved fame or notoriety because of their speaking ability. Verbal performance is a marker of one's intelligence and cognitive brilliance,⁷ which are believed to underlie much of what humans do and accomplish in life.

It seems that the high regard for verbal fluency in the West projects a halo effect on how people perceive and evaluate each other. Research shows that verbally fluent and articulate people are viewed as more intelligent, more creative, and wiser than shy, quiet, and less talkative people.⁸ However, measured objectively, these two groups of people do not show any difference. Even more surprising is the research finding that this basic perception of speaking being associated with higher intelligence is not only endorsed by people who evaluate others, but also by those evaluated. In other words, those who are quiet, shy, and inarticulate concede to the view that they *themselves* are not as intelligent as those who are expressive, talkative, and articulate. These very intriguing research findings point to another possible fundamental psychological error of attributing a characteristic to a person when in fact that person should not be ascribed this characteristic. Apparently, the shaping power of Western culture in people's perceptions of others and self cannot be underestimated.

Speaking in the West is also an act by which the authorship and ownership of ideas is ascertained and admired in communication.⁹ When speaking in public or in organized social settings such as a classroom or a meeting at the workplace, people's ideas, suggestions, or strategies are taken as important contributions to the group goal, as in most other cultures. In the West, however, more emphasis is placed on the identification and acknowledgment of the *individual's* ownership and authorship of expressed ideas and suggestions (see more discussion in the section on classroom discourse in this chapter). For example, the chair of the meeting or teacher of the class is often inclined to comment as part of the flow of communication that "Person A proposed a change of X, but person B disagrees with person A." Here persons A and B are named and highlighted; thereby, the ownership/authorship, not just the contrastive ideas, is acknowledged. A chair or teacher in a similar Chinese setting is likely to contrast the ideas without naming the speakers such as "what do you all think about idea X and idea Y?" As Agnes He's insightful analysis of American Chinese-heritage language classrooms shows,¹⁰ this distinction between the West and Chinese is nontrivial.

Speaking is further testimony of personal character and moral strength. Those who speak up about an issue or speak up to challenge questionable authority are respected and admired by others for having personal courage and integrity. Many well-known whistle blowers in the West are treated as heroes, such as Bethany McLean who revealed (in writing but also speaking)¹¹ the wrongdoing of the Enron Corporation, a Texas-based energy company that was brought down by fraudulent accounting. "Speaking one's mind" is

the phrase used in English to refer to someone who is upright, honest, not willing to compromise principles of morality and ethics. Such a person will express his or her true opinions without regard to intimidation by authority, concern for personal gains, or even fear for personal safety.

Finally, speaking well manifests personal charisma in leadership more than any other behavior. Personal charisma is found not only among people who hold leadership positions, but also among people in simple, daily social life. Those who speak well emerge as natural leaders who attract followers. Charisma as a psychological perception of individuals is defined in the dictionary¹² as “a personal magic of leadership arousing special popular loyalty or enthusiasm for a public figure” or “a special magnetic charm or appeal” of a person. The terms “magic” or “magnetic charm” are not very precise for scientific research. Yet, most people recognize charisma in others when they see it. In the West, speaking well in front of an audience or in a social setting is probably the most identifiable feature of charisma. It would be unthinkable for a person to be viewed as charismatic if that person is an indiscriminately quiet, shy, timid, and inarticulate (e.g., stammering or stuttering in speech).

Speaking as a Right

Among the great legacies that Greek antiquity left to the Western civilization is the due process of trial by jury that was, purportedly, introduced by the goddess Athena, the patron of Athens. According to mythology and dramatization in Aeschylus' trilogy *Oresteia*,¹³ Athena declared that a trial was necessary in Orestes' case (for killing his mother Clytemnestra, who in turn had killed her husband Agamemnon for sacrificing their daughter Iphigenia for the success in the Trojan War). The Furies (deities of vengeance and supernatural personifications of anger or death) were pursuing and condemning Orestes, but it was Athena who stepped in to give each party equal voice. Apollo argued Orestes' case against the Furies in front of the jurors, who then cast a tie vote. Athena's own vote broke the tie and acquitted Orestes in the end.

Undoubtedly, the greatness of this Greek democratic invention for judging disputes between the parties lies in establishing a process that ensures the fairness owed to each party involved.¹⁴ Because of the fairness inherent in this due process, the outcome of judgment is usually regarded as fair and acceptable to both parties. The jurors act on the principle of impartiality, listening and considering each side's argument. To proceed, this very process encourages reason and demands evidence rather than rage and suspicion.

As a result, all sides resort to what is the best mental power available to humans: rational thinking.

Although other cultures may not have invented such as a reason-dependent system, fairness is nevertheless the central and common criterion for judging and ending disputes as well.¹⁵ Some cultures rely on tribal elders for such judgment because they are known to be fair and wise by the community. Other cultures may depend on the judge in the court to hear both sides and cast his or her vote without a jury. For example, the well-known court case as presented in the variety play *Chalk Circle* (灰闌記) by Chinese playwright Li Xingdao (李行道, during Yuan Dynasty 1206–1368),¹⁶ portrayed two women who claimed to be the birthmother of the same child. Judge Bao (999–1062) drew a chalk circle on the floor and ordered the child to be placed in the middle. The two women were asked to use their strength to pull the child to their sides. Whoever succeeded in pulling the child to her side would be declared the birthmother. Of course, the one who loved the child could not bring herself to hurt the child and let him go. Judge Bao declared this mother to be the real mother. The dramatized court case still captures readers' interest in the judge because he, like his Western predecessor King Solomon, employed the humanistic ruling in addition to fairness (pulling the child from equal distance).

What sets the Greek system apart from these other systems is that the former required verbal argumentation from both sides as it unfolded in real time. The parties had to speak in order to present and argue for or against their case in front of the jury and the judge. In Classical Athens, there were no legal experts – that is, prosecution and defense attorneys – as we have today. Instead, the litigants had to deliver their own speeches in court.¹⁷ The essential role of speech was apparent. Thus, it was not just reason, but *verbalized* reason, that mattered in the Athenian system. In contrast, the revered Chinese Judge Bao did not depend on verbalized argument to rule. Instead, he acted out his argument by drawing the circle and by having the two women act as well. In fact, no reference was given to whether the judge even explained his reasoning and his humanistic act to anyone at the court. It is quite conceivable that the attendants of the case, including the plaintiff and the defendant, were kept mystified each step of the way until the judge delivered his verdict at the very end. The entire process unfolded without much need to speak. When the final judgment was made, everyone understood it. But it was not possible for the Athenian court to proceed without the verbal give and take, presentation, refuting, challenging, and conclusion.

The Athenian trial court laid the foundation for the subsequent Western legal system. The direct lineage of present-day Western trial system to the Athenian trial court is clear. All Western courts since Greek time have been accusing and defending via oral argumentation, presentation, cross-examination, and building and challenging each other's credibility to persuade the jury and the judge for a fair ruling.

But what is more significant in the West is that speaking is not only a granted legal right, but, more importantly, a political right that all people enjoy. In the U.S. Constitution as in every other Western nation's constitution, freedom of speech is a right that is guaranteed to every citizen. Speaking – that is, voicing one's political, social, and personal views – has become part and parcel of Western democracy and much of daily work, education, and social life. The right to speak is a right that cannot be challenged and denied by anyone, any organization, or any institution. As such, the public demands and is encouraged to participate in debates, by radio, TV, town hall meetings, and calling their political representatives and leaders about any issue that concerns the nation, the state/providence, the local community, and the person himself or herself. Any attempt by anyone to silence people is shunned and cause for legal action.

Speaking as Leadership

The role of speaking has also been an important shining beam that penetrated across the temporality and complexity of the history of Western civilization. The power of speaking is, unequivocally, linked to the power of leadership. In Greek antiquity, delivering speeches was a primary means to achieve legal and political goals. Like all litigants, politicians had to rely on oration to persuade each other and the people of their intentions and ambitions. Oration was thus essential to propose ideas, to form political factions and alliances, to mobilize the military, to attack one's political enemies, and to clear one's name. Those who emerged on top were revered as master orators and sought after as teachers for youth. The "Ten Attic Orators" were upheld on the pedestal, not only during the classical era (500–400 BCE), but remained influential in subsequent millennia.¹⁸ One of these orators, Demosthenes (384–322 BCE), has come down through the ages as the greatest orator. His oratory achievement enabled him to become an accomplished statesman who defended Athens' liberty against the encroaching power of Macedon.¹⁹ Likewise, during the Roman time, Cicero (106–43 CE), among many other eloquent men, was regarded as the second greatest orator after

Demosthenes. As a statesman, philosopher, political theorist, and lawyer, Cicero, too, used his oratory prowess to achieve his political goals.²⁰

These masters of oration from the ancient times have served as inspiration for later generations of leaders. Delivering speeches has been an integral part of public life in the West. From Robespierre and Danton's zeal of the French Revolution to Hitler's ability to arouse people's support, from Churchill to Roosevelt during World War II, from Kennedy to Clinton to Blair in recent decades, and from Martin Luther King of the American civil rights movement to the history-changing Obama, the West has a long and impressive list of political leaders who distinguished themselves as eloquent speakers. A triumphant example is the British King George VI who overcame a great personal challenge, his stammer, and succeeded in delivering a key speech to his people at the dawn of World War II. He was revered and followed then and is still celebrated today.

In democratic societies, such oratorical skill is of utmost importance for running campaigns, directing movements, and managing crises in order to galvanize voters' support. Within the legislature of the government, oral debates are the primary means to deliberate on any legislative issue and process. And the entire process is watched, analyzed, and responded to, via media commentaries, publicly. Senators and members of Congress engage routinely in oral argumentation for or against a given bill. In light of the fundamental role of speech, it is simply unthinkable how Western-style democracy could possibly proceed and function without verbal procedure and performance.

Beyond the political scene, Western religious leaders are the backbone of holding communities together for spiritual and moral guidance. Christianity with its many denominations as well as Judaism are practiced with sermons and exhortations, with the priest, minister, reverend, and the rabbi delivering a speech to arouse or enlighten the congregation. Anyone who aspires to become a religious leader in a community needs to master the skill of delivering speeches that resonate with profundity and elegance. This very skill may hold the key to whether the church can retain the congregation. Indeed, for many people, the decision to continue or not to continue to attend a given church in a particular town hinges on whether one likes the quality of the sermons.

In the secular life aside from politics, such as industry, business, or school, the speaking ability of a leader is equally important. Leaders have frequent need to address the whole organization or teams to report the organization's operations, performance, and plans. Leaders' speaking skill matters even more when the organization faces uncertainties, challenges, and crises. Almost without exception, those leaders who can convey the

organization's vision and articulate the important issues to its people effectively are likely to succeed in leading their organization.

Speaking as Art

In the West, speaking is not only a distinct personal quality, a right, and a leadership trait, but also an art. This very conception also dates back again to Greek antiquity. Significantly, oratory, the art of speaking, was not purely thought of as a personal talent or intelligence,²¹ unlike our current understanding, but a skill that one can learn, practice, and perfect. An inspirational model is Demosthenes' self-training with pebbles in his mouth to control his stuttering and practicing against the roaring sea to improve his articulation.

The earliest experts who made oratory a profession were the sophists in ancient Greece. Sophists were the itinerant intellectuals who taught youth rhetoric and oratory – that is, how to use language well in order to persuade or convince others (given that Greek litigants had to give personal speeches to present and argue their cases in court). Socrates was thought by some of his contemporaries a sophist because he, too, parsed words and posed many questions in order to force his interlocutors to examine their own thoughts and beliefs. He, too, taught youth and had many followers. However, there was a large difference between Socrates and the sophists: Socrates offered free teaching whereas sophists charged a fee for teaching oratory and rhetoric. It was said that sophists' teaching was a lucrative profession. Despite the criticisms levied against sophism (they might have comprised moral principles by manipulating language for personal gain), sophists attracted many students and followers.²² Sophists took on this specialized intellectual terrain and made a craft out of language and speaking itself, rather than exercising mental prowess per se as exemplified by Socrates. They left a uniquely Western legacy that has not only lasted millennia, but is also more flourishing now and highly likely to continue to blossom owing to the importance of media in our present world.

There have been many notable figures who contributed to this Western legacy, but three stand out for advancing the theory, standard, and education of oratory in the West: Aristotle, Cicero, and Quintilian. Aristotle proposed in his *the Art of Rhetoric*²³ the three core components of any persuasive speech: ethos, pathos, and logos.²⁴ Ethos is the moral character that the speaker needs to convey in order to have credibility before the audience. From our current time, moral character and credibility can be established by drawing on authority of knowledge such as scientific evidence, the

position the speaker holds that is publicly honored, such as a court judge or a CEO of a reputable company, or proven accuracy of information such as a journalist's investigation. Pathos is the use of emotional appeal to influence the audience's perception and judgment. Speakers can use all contents and forms such as stories, anecdotes, tragedies, comedies, jokes, and metaphors, to arouse the audience's emotion in order to win over their support for the speech.

Logos is the employment of reasoning, which, as stated in other chapters, is a central concept in the Western intellectual tradition. Speakers can establish objectivity by presenting information in an unbiased fashion, such as stating the facts without personal commentaries and judgment. Speakers can also give evenhanded treatment of a given topic or issue and let the audience draw its own conclusion. Inductive and deductive reasoning are key strategies. Using examples to support an argument is an effective strategy of inductive reasoning. Using proofs – that is, logical steps without the interference from unrelated and extraneous information – is deductive reasoning. Take an example from our current public issues, the speaker can present a commonly known fact as a starting point, such as “every day, X number of animal species are extinguished, and the cause of such a pace of extinction is human destruction of animal habitats.” Cutting down trees is an incidence of such human destruction. Therefore, preserving trees is necessary, and everyone should do so.

Cicero's influence on oratory is through his book *On the Orator*,²⁵ in addition to his own well-known speeches. Cicero considered oratory the “divine art” in the voice of one of the debating characters in his book. In this book, he treated a great many topics of oratory, ranging from the education of the orator and the responsibility of the orator to the scope of oration and the technical elements of oratory. Cicero emphasized the importance of all forms of appeal such as emotion, humor, irony, digression, and pure reasoning. He also outlined the method of oratory into five sequential parts called the “fundamentals of rhetoric.”

Invention (*inventio*) is the process that leads the orator to the development and refinement of an argument. After the argument is formed, the orator uses arrangement (*dispositio*) to determine how it should be structured effectively, usually in a logical order by importance. With the speech content developed and structure laid out, the orator focuses next on style (*elocutio*) and presentation (*pronuntiatio*). The orator then retains all these elements in memory (*memoria*) by recalling each of the elements during the speech. Finally, the orator delivers (*actio*) to the audience the speech with grace, dignity, gesture, and modulation of voice and face.

But the most significant argument that Cicero made was that an orator needed a broad education, studying not just the techniques of giving a speech, but addressing the general and broader questions. For example, if a person was wrongfully accused of treachery, the orator should not just speak about the specifics of the accusation, but also on the significant harm done to the culture, society, and citizenry as a whole. Thus, an orator needed to study law, politics, history, literature, ethics, warfare, medicine, and mathematics. In fact, only after the person had studied these and other subjects sufficiently could he become a good orator. He introduced the idea of the “ideal orator” who is well versed and well rounded in all branches of human learning. This very idea of a well-educated person being able to use his or her broad knowledge to express thoughts and opinions is the essence of what is known today as Western liberal arts education. Owing its origin to Cicero, this very Western core of higher education has enjoyed the testing of time and now embraced by other cultures.

Building on Cicero's ideas and works of other influential orators before him, Quintilian (35–100 CE) wrote his treatise, *The Orator's Education*, on the education of the “perfect” orator from birth to old age.²⁶ He detailed the whole process of how to select a nurse for the orator in the beginning, how to train in reading, writing, grammar, and literary criticism, how to exercise oratory composition, and how to craft full legal and political speeches in the end. Like Cicero, Quintilian emphasized the usage of many materials such as fables, narratives, humor, and comparisons. His training curriculum became the standard component of education for subsequent centuries.

Of the Western traditions, Judaism places a very high, if not the highest, value on education. Most fundamentally, the practice of traditional Judaism has a high barrier to entry: Any serious Jew must be able to read and understand biblical Hebrew, for that is the language of the liturgy and the sacred texts. Beyond the basic texts, the most frequently studied and most important of the Jewish law codes are written in Aramaic, which requires assiduous, dedicated studies (if one page is studied each day, it takes seven and a half years to study the entire Talmud). Anyone who has completed the project is held in extremely high regard. Furthermore, according to some rabbis, it is required that scholars study in a *chavruta*, or pair (it is highly discouraged to study Talmud and Torah on one's own). A *chavruta* is considered to have major spiritual and social significance, as it is written, “When two scholars of the Torah listen to one another, God hears their voices” (Talmud Shabbat 63a). Also as an integral part of the tradition, scholars are encouraged to debate and disagree about the text at hand, for the Talmud itself is not a listing of laws, but a record of conversations and debates between the

ancient rabbis themselves. Jewish children celebrate bar mitzvah (for the boys) and bat mitzvah (for the girls) as a rite of passage into adulthood at age thirteen and twelve, respectively, at which point they are considered competent to pass the Jewish tradition on to the next generation. A key part of this celebration is the required chanting of a portion from the Torah and delivering a commentary on the Torah portion of the week in front of the entire congregation. The child spends much time studying with a teacher and preparing for the ceremony for the day.²⁷

To date, throughout Western university campuses, the basic art of public speaking and training methods are taught commonly to students. Such courses enjoy enduring popularity²⁸; often students have to be put on long waiting lists to get a place in such a course. While in the course, students study many speeches as models, such as Martin Luther King's famous speech *I Have a Dream* as a video or audio recording. Students then draft their own speeches on a topic of their interest. They work with the professor to perfect their speeches and then deliver them to their fellow students as an audience. Frequently, the audience peers critique each other's speeches according to the models, formats, and standards they study. As a result, students improved their speaking skills and become informed consumers or even connoisseurs of the verbal art of public speaking. As mentioned previously, Western students are encouraged to master the skill of debating, from middle school onward. They participate in both intra-school and inter-school competitions, and the winners arise to the city, state, and national levels. Those who won recognition are highly sought after for college admissions by selective universities.

In present-day universities, communication and modern media studies are common majors for undergraduate students and specialized graduate programs. In addition, every high school and university teaches drama on stage. Students receive training on how to project their voice, how to act with words, and how to deliver their ideas and emotions effectively on stage. These opportunities undoubtedly indicate the importance of such skills on the one hand and provide students with actual skill development on the other. Finally, professional speechwriters are also in high demand by political, business, and other organizational leaders. Those who master the art of public speaking and those who can help leaders deliver successful speeches are respected, admired, and sought after.

Given the importance speaking assumes in the West, it seems that the default mode of Western communication is to speak whenever one is faced with a choice of speaking or not speaking. The West thus privileges speaking and speakership. By doing so, it devalues, or values much less than other cultures, not speaking, silence, and listenership.

WESTERN SPEAKING STYLE

Thus far, I have discussed the overarching importance of speaking throughout Western history. In this section, I turn to the topic of speaking style as it pertains to communication both in organized settings and in daily life.

In the 1970s, the philosopher H. P. Grice proposed his well-known conversational rules that govern how people talk to each other in daily communication.²⁹ His four maxims of “cooperative principles” have become the guidepost for understanding what in human communication underlies the content of people’s speech. As will be seen, these conversational rules, or talking grammar, initially conceived of as universal human conversational patterns, may not be that universal after all. Nevertheless, they are more commonly observed and therefore more particular to Western people’s speech than in other cultures.

The Maxim of Quantity: Speak No More and No Less

Grice noticed that when speaking, people in general are quite conscious of the notion of quantity – that is, the *amount* of speech as required in a conversational context. For example, when asked by a friend “where are you going?” on a campus street, the reply is usually “the gym.” Few people would take the trouble to utter the full sentence, “I am going to the gym.” The first part is unnecessary in the context because it is well understood by the first party. If instead the speaker said the full sentence, it would likely lead the interlocutor to form a number of undesirable impressions about the speaker, such as: (1) the speaker is not attentive; (2) the speaker is inappropriate or quirky because he/she would take the trouble to say something unnecessary; (3) the speaker is joking or being sarcastic, but for no apparent cause; (4) something may be bothering this speaker so as to make him/her behave strangely.

Although speaking is highly valued, sheer verbosity and jabber without providing the requested information is regarded as a waste of time even in this kind of mundane communication between people. Put in another way, the idea of “necessity” in speech quantity reflects quite clearly the concern of *economy* or *efficiency*, a sensitivity to quantity in life that is an integral part of the West since Greek time (which is the foundation for scientific thinking).³⁰ Speaking in this manner confirms and continues how the West parses and construes the world in the domain of human verbal interaction.

It is important to point out that maintaining the efficiency of speaking is not just a task for isolated speakers to attend, but a joint, cooperative

process for everyone as mandated by the culture. As such, interlocutors share this understanding and talk accordingly. As will be seen in the section on the Chinese speaking style, this type of speech driven by a concern and calculation of necessity, economy, and efficiency may be a speech faux pas that is likely to lead to the breakdown of the conversation rather than cooperation and continuation of the conversation.

The Maxim of Quality: Speak Truth and Avoid Falsehood

This Gricean maxim is of high importance in speaking. In general, it is unlikely that people in any culture intentionally speak falsehood without any reason. Grice is correct in his analysis about this universal human tendency. However, the extreme premium placed on speaking truth is, I would argue, characteristically Western. This tendency reflects Western emphasis on the moral standard of *honesty* that weighs heavily in judging each other's character and moral integrity. Those who are perceived as less straightforward in their speaking are suspected of dishonesty and consequently distrusted by others. Research indeed shows that Western people express aversion toward circumlocution – that is, indirect and beat-around-the-bush kind of talking. People who are identified as speaking circumlocution are viewed as manipulative because they have something to hide. Truth telling is preferred regardless of circumstances, even when truth may hurt.³¹ Even though hurtful truth may be hard to swallow, its tellers are often seen as courageous and heroic and therefore are extended greater admiration and trust in a workplace and even in intimate relationships. It was not an accident that Al Gore's celebrated documentary film on human responsibility for our deteriorating planet, which won him the Nobel Peace Prize, is called "An Inconvenient Truth."

Whereas other cultures may differentiate certain areas of life, or some areas to a greater degree, as off limit or improper for truth telling (out of concern for the listener's well-being, emotional distress, or social awkwardness), the West may insist on fewer such areas, or a narrower range of areas. For example, if a parent is terminally ill, the adult child and even a younger child may be viewed as entitled to the truth about the parent's condition, even though telling this truth may be very distressful and hurtful. But in Chinese culture, family members may conceal the information about a terminally ill parent from a daughter who lives afar and without any means to travel to pay a visit to her parent. The daughter may not be told about the parent's death until the parent has been buried and the bereavement ceremony over, at a time when the family ascertains the daughter's better ability

to travel. Telling the truth to the daughter beforehand may be regarded as an inhumane act on the part of the family, knowing that the daughter would be grieving alone without any family support. Thus, speaking such truth may indeed be curtailed, and not speaking such truth may be regarded as more appropriate.³²

Consistent with the Gricean maxim, it is common to hear Western people preempt their speech relaying accuracy of the information or accountability of the opinion as follows:

This is just my opinion ...; this is my two cents ...;

I am not an expert, but I ...;

As I recall ..., it appears to be ...; it seems to be ...; I may be ...; it might have been ...;

I don't suppose we ...; I assume that this ...;

But it is rare to hear Western people preempt their speech with “from my *stupid* opinion, I would say ...,” “in my *humble* view, I think ...,” and “apologizing for my ignorance, I ...” – a style quite commonly observed among Asian speakers. The Western style of preempting speech is anchored on truth or assumed truth in question or fending off any potential charge against the speaker's untrue statement – that is, the quality of the information about to be presented. The Asian style, on the other hand, is not about the quality of information, but about humility – that is, a virtuous quality of the speaker him- or herself.

The Maxim of Relevance: Speak to the Point

Grice's maxim of relevance is related to his notion of quantity. This maxim requires sensitivity to logic and privileges its use as a guide in communication. The idea of “to the point” or “make a point,” so commonly encountered in Western people's speaking, emphasizes the *precision* and *conciseness* of information or opinion expressed. Those judged as sharp usually are those able to identify the relevant and the essential from the irrelevant and unessential and speak with precision about the matters. Much of the speaker's persuasive power lies in this maxim.

If speaking has a clear goal such as political, social, religious, commercial, and work-related, Western speakers show a heightened sense of the message and message delivery in their speech. This message orientation is described as sender-centered,³³ which is reflective of the great Western oratorical and rhetorical tradition. The speaker's focus is mainly on how to formulate the best message to convey to the audience. Topics that concern

the speaker are how to frame the issue, how to set the tone, how to improve the source of credibility, and how to increase the significance of the message. As a matter of cultural cooperation, Western audience also expects a “significant message” from the speaker.³⁴

Convoluting speaking – the opposite of relevant speaking – long-windedness, or inability to speak to the point is regarded as a sign of lack of intelligence and a disappointment. Listeners lose interest and patience with people who mumble on without any point to make.³⁵ At meetings in the workplace, we frequently hear Western people say “we’ve already talked about that, can we move on?” “can you clarify the relevance of X?” or “you talked about X, but what is the issue you came to talk about?” These questions are not taken as anything offensive to the speaker, but as a signal that the audience has no more patience or need to listen to the speaker and that the speaker should either speak to the relevant point, or the conversation needs to turn to another topic.

But even when speaking does not have a clear goal as previously discussed, speakers in daily conversations are also cognizant of the elements of relevance. At dinner table, if a husband asks his wife to share how her day was, she is also attentive to the relevance of the information she is providing. Her husband, likewise, may remind her that she may have taken too long to finish her story or even tell her to “cut to the chase.” When friends see each other, they share their life stories. But such sharing also needs to be carried out in a manner consistent with the maxim of relevance under discussion or sharing.

As will be discussed in the Asian section, this type of to-the-point talking can often be offensive to people, and not uncommonly even lead to a breakdown of relationships. Frequently, speaking with precision is regarded as inappropriate in hierarchical relationships either at home, work, or in class, and as flat-out rude, impatient, and disrespectful in a variety of Asian contexts.

The Maxim of Clarity: Speak Directly

This maxim first concerns the need for clarity when speaking in any context. The idea is to avoid obscurity, making clear what one intends to convey without the risk of the listener misconstruing the speaker’s information. Again, the burden is on the speaker to make his or her message unambiguous so as to ease the reception of the message. Any kind of unclear speech ranging from utterances to articulation and arguments should be avoided. Prime examples of speech successes and failures are found in political

campaigns. Without exemption, political consultants, analysts, and news commentators focus on the clarity or lack of clarity of important political speeches whenever they provide any post-speech analysis. Interestingly, by characterizing the level of clarity of a speech, these professionals, in a way, either help increase or reduce the effect of a given message.

In daily communication, family members, friends, and school peers also share the view that if one wants other people to know what one wants, one needs to speak up and make one's desire clear. The idiom "the squeaky wheel gets the grease" is actually not just about the loudness of speaking, but loudness of speaking one's desire *clearly* and *unambiguously* so that others will hear the squeaky sound but not some other sound and be likely to respond to one's expressed need. Similarly, a husband may say to his wife, "Please do not ask me to read your mind; please tell me what you want." Romantic partners succeed more when they are able to express their desires and needs clearly and appropriately to each other. Undoubtedly, friendship making also depends on involved parties having the social competence to express their desires, likes, dislikes, shared interests, and issues clearly to each other. Waiting for the other to construe one's needs and preferences is likely to lead one to be friendless.³⁶

The maxim of clarity does not concern only clarity in daily conversation, but also a large cultural mandate of speaking *directly* and *unambiguously*.³⁷ As noted previously, speaking directly rests first on the moral standard of honesty and transparency in personal conduct. Accordingly, one should speak one's mind without withholding information. Then one strives to present, explain, or argue clearly so that the audience will understand one's information, reasoning, and position. Muddying the water, obscuring an otherwise clear issue, or making confusing statements is considered less desirable or even unethical if the speaker is known to purposely create obscurity and confusion.

WESTERN CLASSROOM DISCOURSE AND SOCIALIZATION

With little doubt, children are not born possessing a particular speaking style. Their style is a result of socialization and personal development. Because speaking in the West is not just a private activity but a desired skill for citizens, social participants, and contributors at work and school, much of the training and socialization of speaking in the way previously described takes place in school. The large research literature that focuses on speaking in school concerns classroom discourse. Although this section of

the chapter cannot do full justice to this research literature, it is still helpful to highlight some key aspects of classroom discourse in the West.

Classroom discourse in the West covers the whole scope of verbal interaction between teachers and students. It ranges from teacher talk, student talk, teacher–student talk, and student–student talk to how each of these talks unfolds, how each step functions in these talks, and what goal is achieved by each kind and each process. For example, by looking at teacher–student talk, researchers examine how much time each talk takes (time allocation), how each talk functions (e.g., presents/offers information, asks closed-ended versus open-ended questions), whether the talk aims at learning tasks or non-learning tasks (e.g., classroom logistics), how different kinds of talk facilitate or impede learning, and what kinds of discourse lead to better student achievement.³⁸ Research has found, to the disappointment of many, that teacher talk remains predominant, despite much avowed belief in change and much teacher training to the contrary.³⁹

As researchers acknowledge, classroom discourse in the West has undergone much change, from traditional training of oratory in the distant past, to the emphasis on the aesthetics of oral performance in the nineteenth and early twentieth century (“echo the voice of high culture”),⁴⁰ to the current authenticity of popular oracy, the expressive forms of talking, as lived experiences that children bring to school. Nevertheless, the classroom, where formal schooling is compulsory, still strongly adheres to the commitment to speaking as a cognitive, intellectual activity and skill to be mastered by schoolchildren. Starting from preschool, children are taught to verbalize their thoughts and feelings. “Use your words,” “tell me in your own words,” or “I can’t tell what you want to do if you don’t say it” are common instructions preschool teachers give to young children to urge them to verbalize their desires, intentions, and actions.⁴¹ For older children, although lived oracy is recognized and sometimes even embraced as an entry point for children to ground their talk training in school, their end goal is not to stay in their familiar community speech, but to reach a higher level of culture of the educated.⁴² Such classroom teaching still aims at helping children achieve communicative competence that stresses conveying information concisely, clearly, and fluently. Children still need to learn how to present a thesis backed with evidence, how to argue, and how to persuade the audience through the manipulation of language. Hewitt and Inghilleri⁴³ observed British classroom activities where children were taught how to deliver speeches to their class and how to engage in the ensuing discussion afterward. The researchers’ analysis indicated that children learned how to

disagree and how to argue despite the fact that they use much more cooperation-dominated speech outside of school.

A key characteristic in Western classroom discourse, as pointed out by Mary O'Connor and Sarah Michaels, is to help each student take him- or herself seriously as a learner.⁴⁴ The significance of this teaching anchors in the notion that each student is the *author/owner* of his or her own ideas. Intellectual socialization is thus thought to lead students into the realm of their own ideas vis-à-vis others' ideas and the take-on of each other's ideas through verbal interaction.

O'Connor and Michaels drew on two related sociolinguistic theories as a lens to show how this type of teaching takes place in an American middle school. The first theory, as advanced by Goodwin,⁴⁵ addresses the speaking rights and responsibilities by students as structured in a classroom discourse. For example, when a student (A) asks another (B), "May I have that crayon?" another student, not participating in the dialogue (C), may interject, "No, he is giving it to me." The bystander (C) then denies the right of the student to whom the question was addressed (B) to answer Student A's question. But Student A can also say, "Wait a minute, I was the first to ask for the crayon!" As such, classroom discourse affords students opportunities to recognize, take, and negotiate their rights and responsibilities. The second theory, by Goffman, delineates the roles of the "animator" and "author" in human communication.⁴⁶ By the puppeteering metaphor, an animator is one who produces an utterance – that is, animating oneself or the other through talk. But an author is one from whom beliefs and sentiments originate, and the author's beliefs and sentiments can be uttered by him- or herself or any animator. In classroom discourse, students and the teacher take on these roles in their academic learning.

As O'Connor and Michaels' observational research shows, the finely attuned teacher plays a unique role because he or she becomes the animator that does two essential things for students: (1) highlights the ownership/authorship of students' ideas and (2) links students' own ideas to the greater sphere of their culture. The researchers call this strategy "revoicing." With regard to (1), they give an example of a routine verbal interaction between the teacher and the students where one student suggested a solution to a science task that was different from another student's idea. The masterful teacher then interjected by saying: "So then, you don't agree with Sarita that ..."⁴⁷ By doing so, as O'Connor and Michaels explain, the teacher reformulated the original utterance as a disagreement, which is an intellectually more demanding level. Second, the teacher signaled the student to use her

speaking right to “validate her inference, and, thus, take on a position herself.” Thirdly, the teacher deliberately placed two students in opposition and primed them to evaluate the merits of their own and each other’s proposals. The teacher effectively led the students to the very notion that they were the authors/owners of their ideas and that they have the right to take a position to validate, defend, challenge, or affirm other people’s interpretations of their ideas. By doing so, the teacher alerts the students to the significance of their intellectual contributions in the classroom.

Regarding the second way of “revoicing,” O’Connor and Michaels presented an example where the teacher elicited multiple suggestions from students for deciding what were the most popular mass transit trips people make. After students gave their ideas, the teacher asked how they made their personal guesses, prompting students to find evidence for their claims. One by one, students gave their reasons. One student said that she liked the way a terminal looked. The teacher then revoiced the student’s reason as “So you chose ... based on your *own personal experience*.” Another student confirmed that he, too, named the first student’s choice because “a lot of people like to ride on the train for a long time ... some might just ride ... just for the heck of it.” The teacher then recast the utterance “So you made your guess based on what *you know about human behavior*?”⁴⁸ Both students concurred. Clearly, these student initial ideas were cruder, weaker, and less well formed. But the skillful teacher elevated their ideas to more standard knowledge and a larger intellectual scope without qualitatively altering the students’ original ideas. By doing so, the teacher provided a chance for students to claim full credit for the intellectual merit of their own, albeit elevated, ideas, thus recognizing their individual potential, growth, and greatness.

GROWING UP A DEVIL’S ADVOCATE

While school plays an essential role in socializing children into the desired roles of speakers in the West, home also plays a compatible role. In fact, there is strong evidence that Western children are more encouraged to speak from an early age. When babies are born, Western mothers (as other caregivers) talk to them more than Asian mothers (and other Asian caregivers) do to their infants. As soon as babies can vocalize, their caregivers engage them in talking as if they were real conversational partners. When caregivers hear their babies’ babbling, cooing, and jargoning, they respond with more talking and excitement. Compared to the rest of the world’s cultures, Western caregivers talk most to their infants and toddlers.⁴⁹

When children reach preschool age and beyond, parents engage them in more talking. Research shows that Western parents prefer a particular style called elaboration. Shirley Brice Heath's landmark research on the differences among European-American middle-class and working-class as well as African-American parents in home language socialization in the early 1980s⁵⁰ shows how similarly European-American middle-class parents talk to their children at home as in school. Children were asked questions to which parents already knew the answers. Children were encouraged to recount and reflect on events in the past when they had been guided to intellectualize their lived experiences. This kind of talking style was followed up with more extensive research in the areas of children's autobiographical memory development, which is a core component of the self and self-making.⁵¹ Accordingly, when reminiscing about a past experience, the mother will probe the child for what happened, how the event happened, and why it happened that way. This elaborative style provides the child with the opportunity to *account for* and to *explain/interpret* the past experience, or, if the talk is about a future event, about what will happen next. Here the child is afforded the opportunity to *predict* future events based on the information at hand. Verbally accounting, explaining/interpreting, and predicting events in the world as children experience them emphasize the authorship and ownership of the child's autobiography on the one hand and the analytical and narrative skill on the other. Undoubtedly, such a talking style prepares children for school where further training for speaking takes place.

As an important part of this early training for speaking, Western caregivers offer much modeling and room for children to elaborate on their feelings and emotions about the event, particularly when the experience and feelings are positive.⁵² For example, a mother may say to her four-year-old daughter, "How did it make you feel when your friend Suzie invited you to swim together?" If the child just says "good," the mother may probe further, "What's good about that?" or "Did that not make you feel that Suzie likes you?" This emphasis enables the child to develop verbalization about his or her inner world, attitude, opinions, and emotional responses to her own experiences.

Noteworthy is a particular kind of speaking socialization that many well-educated Western parents offer to their children: the practice of the devil's advocate. Devil's advocate – originally from the canonization process of the Roman Catholic Church – has come to refer to someone who takes a position with which he or she does not necessarily agree simply for the sake of argument. The purpose of the devil's advocate is to expose flaws and

weaknesses of the argument. As a result, the original argument becomes stronger. For example, if one argues that bottled water is a waste of money because it is no cleaner than tap water, as research shows, the interlocutor can say, "Just to be a devil's advocate, people may still buy bottled water because it makes them feel safer." As a result, the first person can include this perspective in the argument by saying, "Although people may feel they are doing something to protect their health by buying bottled water, it does not give them any health benefits. In fact, they are just throwing money away." The revised argument is better because it juxtaposes the flawed psychological reason next to scientific evidence for people's purchase of bottled water. In a similar vein, parents also model for children by using phrases such as "in fairness, I can see . . .," "taking the other side's perspective, I can sympathize with . . . although I disagree with them." Indeed, socializing children in practicing the devil's advocate can foster children's argumentation skill that is treasured in their culture.

DISTRUST IN SPEAKING IN EAST ASIA

Unlike the high value attached to verbal eloquence in the West, East Asia has an absence of such a value. We could easily name a long list of great speakers in the West, but we could name *none* in East Asia, not even after an ardent search through the triumphant democracies of Japan, Korea, and Taiwan where eloquence of public speaking is supposed to matter. Even the great Gandhi was not known for his words but for his nonviolent deeds: sitting, marching, and fighting *quietly* despite his unprecedented, monumental moral and political achievement. As it turns out, it is not an accident, or mere failure, or regrettable incompetence that East Asia does not have such a tradition. The reason is that it actually devalues – or more appropriately put, distrusts – verbal eloquence as a means to achieve worthy ends.

To begin with, none of the three major spiritual traditions – Taoism, Buddhism, and Confucianism – emphasizes speaking. Taoism regards as infinite wisdom human harmony with nature, fitting into the seamless unity without the need to speak, as expressed in the well-known phrase by Lao Tzu: "[T]hose who understand are not talkers; talkers don't understand."⁵³ Buddhism pursues meditation as a means to quiet down the mind and to be rid of worldly desires in order to achieve personal enlightenment. Furthermore, East Asia never had a comparable (to the Greek) political or legal system that promoted public speaking. Undoubtedly, these important historical forces played a role in the lack of an oratory tradition. However, the East Asian attitude toward speaking was not formed by chance but by a

serious intellectual, moral, political, and social discourse that took place at the time when their cultural foundation was laid down.⁵⁴ Subsequent development further solidified this foundation into a long-lasting tradition.

The most influential discourse was, undoubtedly, led by the Confucians. Because the core of his teaching emphasized learning to become fully humane – that is, to follow the path of moral self-cultivation throughout life – Confucius saw the ultimate measure of this personal development as lying in what a person *does*, not what a person *says*. From the very beginning, Confucius recognized that the greatest challenge of such a personal moral project is anchored in the discrepancy between what a person can desire, will, and even resolve and what the person actually does and practices. Thus, Confucius, to use a modern term, problematized this personal life path as the constant struggle between one's words and one's deeds. Consistency between these two sides is the gauge of and feedback of one's own moral self-cultivation. Therefore, a person's speaking cannot be divorced from his or her moral character. Speaking is not just one's cognition and knowledge or any spontaneous, freestanding utterance, but a reflection of one's moral quality. For one to make real progress on this path, one needs to work at one's deeds rather than one's words. Those who pursue moral self-perfection must be cautious about their words. Clearly, the Confucian discussion about speaking is framed not to explore the cognitive and linguistic nature of human communication, but to compare what one chooses to talk about to what goals one tries to achieve.⁵⁵

Inspection of the *Analects* reveals a rich discourse on the relationship between one's speaking and moral/virtuous development. As far as I can discern, Confucius discussed mainly three kinds of problems with verbal craftiness, all of which are potential impediments to one's moral self-cultivation: (1) a glib tongue divorces the mind from heart, (2) flattering speech undermines sincerity, and (3) boastful speech lacks humility.

Out of all kinds of problematic speaking, Confucius admitted himself that he regarded a glib tongue most difficult to accept. A glib tongue (巧言 or 佞人), sometimes translated as "sharp tongue" or "clever talk," is the kind that deceives, manipulates, and pretends, operating with ill intention, hypocrisy, and falsehood. Confucius commented "it is a rare thing for glib speech and an insinuating appearance to accompany authoritative conduct (*ren* 仁),"⁵⁶ and "glib words corrupt virtue,"⁵⁷ and glib talkers are seldom trustworthy. As noted in previous chapters, *ren* is the ultimate humane quality that a person can achieve through life-long learning and practice of self-perfection. Confucius saw people who engage in glib talk as misusing the power of words that are put together by the able mind but apart from the

feeling and caring heart. Such talkers give themselves permission to indulge in ends justifying means at any cost: “[W]hat the exemplary person (*junzi* 君子) hates most is having to declare in favor of something that he has already rejected, and then to have to come up with some excuse for doing so.”⁵⁸ Having witnessed the devastating chaos during the Warring States of his time, Confucius was also wary of the dangers of the glib tongue in causing states to fall apart: “glib people are dangerous” and “I detest the fact that glib-tongued talkers bring down states and families”⁵⁹ because such people can distort and manipulate events and “confuse moral standards”⁶⁰ so as to lead the kings and princes to take wrong actions.

Flattering speech, the second despised kind, undermines the speaker’s sincerity. When one engages in flattery of others without believing in what one is saying, one moves away from sincerity. As noted previously, sincerity occupies a central place in the *ren* conduct by Confucians throughout Chinese history. Ingratiating speech is usually directed toward someone who holds power or has access to resources that the speaker desires for him- or herself. Because the motive is self-serving by pleasing the other, like the ministers in *The Emperor Has No Clothes* by Hans Christian Andersen, ingratiating speech also leads the recipient of flattery to sink further into vanity. Both the speaker and the recipient are denied the opportunity to connect to the virtue of sincerity, thereby losing the opportunity for moral growth. This is why Confucius cautioned against association with “friends who ingratiate and feign compliance” in addition to glib talking.⁶¹ Confucius also regarded excessive, extravagant, and beautiful speech without substance as suffering from the same problem, related to the slyness of ingratiation.

Whereas flattering speech harms the other (as well as the self), boastful speech reveals the speaker’s *own* character flaw. Boastful speech reflects the self as being in need of artificial boosting, inflating the sense of self. This kind of speaking lacks humility, which is another important quality in the *ren* conduct, particularly regarding learning. As discussed in [Chapter 5](#), humility is conceived of by Confucians as a fundamental need and attitude for anyone in learning. When a person engages in self-boasting through speech, that person is not in touch with this very need. The projected positive image is achieved through empty and often aggressive language, but it is not based on real knowledge, wisdom, and moral growth of the person. Boastful speech is therefore more harmful to the self than to the audience because most of the time the audience can detect the overstatement and the weakness of the speaker’s character. In a vivid conversation where Confucius asked four of his students to express their ambitions, one, Zilu, “hastily replied, ‘give me a state of thousand charots⁶² to govern, set me

in among powerful neighbors, harass me with foreign armies, and add to that widespread famine, and at the end of three years, I will have imbued the people with courage, and moreover, provided them with a secure direction.”⁶³ Confucius smiled at Zilu. When another student later inquired why he did so, Confucius responded, “[I]n governing a state you need to observe ritual propriety, and yet in what he said there was no deference at all.”⁶⁴ Apparently, Confucius was unimpressed by Zilu’s boastful and aggressive speech because it lacked humility irrespective of its eloquence (these words were quite eloquent in Chinese).

All three kinds of speech have in common the discrepancy between what is outwardly verbalized and what the internal state of the speaker is. Moreover, Confucius’ concerns focused on the lost opportunity for the speaker to grow further toward the *ren* conduct.

While addressing these three problems of speech, the *Analects* also presents three virtues to counter the three flawed ways of talking: (1) heaven (*tian*, 天) is the speechless, but most virtuous, to be emulated; (2) deeds shall exceed words; and (3) attunement to social context and relationships is necessary for talking.

Confucius and his later followers, but also virtually all schools of thought during his era, revered Heaven, conceived of as an all-encompassing spiritual entity that is intimately involved in human affairs. Great sages and ancestral spirits ascend to *tian* to join an ultimate power that cares, nurtures, watches, regulates, and judges (impartially) how humans operate on their own and with each other. According to Ames and Rosemont,⁶⁵ the Chinese *tian* is not the other world or the Creator as conceptualized in Judeo-Christian tradition, but the world as known to humans. *Tian* is thus the perfection that humans can see, feel, contemplate, emulate, and integrate with. *Tian* is the inspiration for humans as stated in *The Book of Change*: “*Tian* cycles by itself emitting unending strength; the authoritative person shall likewise strive unremittingly (天行健, 君子以自强不息).”⁶⁶

A significant quality of *tian*, as pointed out by Confucius, is *not speaking* (*wuyan*, 無言), yet it nurtures the natural and human world, provides moral ordinances, and extols great human achievements as seen in the sages. In a conversation with his student Zigong, Confucius said that he would leave off speaking. Zigong pursued him further: “If you do not speak, how will we your followers find the proper way?” The Master responded ‘Does *tian* speak? And yet the four seasons turn and the myriad things are born and grow within it.’”⁶⁷ This passage has come down to represent the articulation of “the highest ideal of virtuous behavior”⁶⁸ for which humans are to strive: doing and showing one’s good deeds without the need to speak.

The *Analects* unequivocally articulates the second way to counter our urge to speak: Deeds shall precede and exceed words. By ordering action before and exceeding speech, Confucius highlights the “worth of action.”⁶⁹ Confucius said that “the exemplary persons accomplish what they are going to say, and only then say it”; they want “to be slow to speak yet quick to act”; and “the ancients were loath to speak because they would be ashamed if they personally did not live up to what they said.”⁷⁰ These expressions emphasize the “desire for a speech true to the life and character of the speaker. . . . The lived character of the [speaker] is more important than his speech.” Instead of delineating a “rhetorical silence” as commonly used in the West (e.g., pause for a greater effect on the audience or recusal from speaking to ensure impartiality), the Confucian order of deeds and words “repudiates glibness and puts an emphasis on . . . action. Human character is revealed in our worldly acts, not in the articulation of ideas and plans, not in senseless shouting, pontificating, or manipulating of others.”⁷¹ Not speaking before one’s action or not in accordance to one’s action thus serves to “foreground” full ethical significance of action in contrast to the insignificant, even irrelevant, role of speech.

As part of Confucian discourse on speaking, there is also an emphasis on attunement to social context and relationships, the third virtue for speaking. As noted in [Chapter 2](#), Confucian thought separates neither the moral nor the individual from the social. The individual learns to cultivate self (修身), to regulate family (齊家), to order the state (治國), and ultimately to bring peace to the world (平天下). One’s moral self-perfection is grounded in one’s most primary social realm: the family. Learning how to relate to people in the cosmos of family is learning to understand the world at large. In fact, successful learning in the home is requisite for greater social responsibility for the community. Therefore, learning to speak well is no doubt learning how to speak with attunement to the social contexts and relationships.

Confucius saw as essential the understanding of ritual propriety, *li* (禮) in helping people achieve the goal of speaking appropriately. As discussed in [Chapter 2](#), *li* covers social interactions at all levels ranging from the intimate relationship between friends to ceremonial performance in the larger society. But the key to *li* is to attend to people’s feelings, emotions, and each other’s senses and sensibilities – in other words, attending to humanity. One speaks when the appropriate context calls for it and does not speak or speaks in a particular way so as to promote relationships rather than embarrass or cause distress in the other. Having articulated what *li* is and how it regulates human relationships and interactions, Confucius made many remarks about

speaking with social attunement. When his student Yan Hui inquired about how to practice *li* in order to achieve *ren* in daily life, Confucius replied that not speaking about anything that violates the observance of *li* is one important way.⁷² Confucius remarked further that “by taking care in choice of language and mode of expression, exemplary persons keep vulgarity and impropriety at a distance,” and “speaking before the time to speak is called being rash; not speaking when it is time to speak is called holding back, and speaking without observing the person’s countenance is called being behind.” Confucius himself set a good example for such attunement when he was observed in his home village to speak “deferentially, as though at a loss of words, and yet in the ancestral temple and at court, he spoke articulately, though with deliberation.”⁷³ This basic outline of speaking with social attunement has had a strong influence on Chinese and other East Asians in their daily social interactions.

Clearly, the virtues of speaking lean toward *silence*. However, silence in Chinese and East Asian cultures is not regarded as the absence or opposite of speaking, but a virtue in its own right. As Arabella Lyon points out, silence in the West may be equated with “disengagement and disregard”⁷⁴ or inaction, which is a personal weakness. But Chinese/East Asians respect “chosen silence” as having a significant role to play in human affairs and relationship. For them, “it is a constitutive part of interactions, communication, and even making of fulfillment, knowledge, choice, and commitment. Silence can indicate questions, promises, denial, warning, threats, insult, request, command, deference, and intimacy.”⁷⁵ The *Analects* is a text that offers a full discourse on how silence needs to be understood, valued, and practiced in service of one’s moral and virtuous development.

SPEAKER’S BURDEN

Unlike some other specific cultural practices in the past (e.g., foot-binding or low social status of women) that have been jettisoned in modern time, the tradition of distrust in speaking for anyone in East Asia does not seem to abate. This tenacious persistence can be observed in Japan and Korea despite a well-functioning democracy running for decades and in Hong Kong despite a century-long British colonial rule.⁷⁶ Even though freedom of speech in those democracies is a constitutional right (as well as the right to defend oneself legally) for all, this political and legal right is not to be confused with the *cultural norm* of speaking. The source of this cultural persistence, I suspect, lies in the Confucian persuasion for personal moral development. Even when eloquent speakers emerge as they do, people may

not admire and trust them as much as they do in the West, resulting in less power granted to such speakers. Consequently, political, social, business, and education leaders may not be eager to develop or to display oratory skills either. None of the current Asian political leaders are distinguished speakers. Instead, they project an image of speaking cautiously, slowly, softly, and hesitantly, as exemplified by the UN Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon.

Against this millennia-long cultural background, I would argue that present-day Chinese/East Asian speakers continue to carry three concerns/burdens in weighing their choice of speaking or not speaking as well as how they speak: (1) moral, (2) social, and (3) personal. These sensitivities may dissuade them from speaking more, and more forcefully.

Moral Concern

The notion of speaking versus action as an epistemological consideration weighs heavily on anyone before deciding to speak or not to speak, regardless of the social context and personal risks. Whenever a person is confronted with and contemplates the choice of speaking, he or she is likely to think about whether or not the idea about to be expressed, particularly criticisms and suggestions, can be backed up in action by the person him- or herself. To put this reasoning more simply, speaking in Chinese/East Asian cultures is regarded more as speaking up to voice a concern, to change the status quo, or to offer a promise. The standard of knowing (hence the source of expression), namely epistemology, is not merely cognitive but the *practice* of what one knows.⁷⁷ Thus, words are not finished when merely spoken, and the message alone is not enough until the words turn into practice. In East Asia, speaking commits the speaker to action and delivery of deeds. If one is unsure about this action-commitment and delivery, one would be better served to remain silent. Such chosen silence is understood, respected, and valued.

Research indeed shows this tendency of present-day Chinese. Kwan and colleagues⁷⁸ used a common instrument for measuring individuation in the West and found that Hong Kong Chinese regarded this measure as consisting of two factors: (1) attention seeking for oneself and (2) taking the lead for the group. Whereas attention seeking for oneself is a negative characteristic, taking the lead on behalf of the group is a positive behavior. Statements indicating attention seeking include “raise your hand to ask a question in a meeting or lecture,” “publicly challenge a speaker whose position clashes with your own,” “give an informal talk in front of a small group of classmates,” “speak up about your ideas even though you are uncertain of

whether you are correct,” and “give your opinion on a controversial issue, even though no one has asked for it.” In contrast, taking the lead include “give a lecture to a large audience,” “volunteer to head a committee for a group of people you do not know very well,” “accept a nomination to be a leader of a group,” and “perform on a stage before a large audience.” As can be seen, the statements on attention seeking all involve public speaking. Given the moral burden for holding the speaker personally accountable for his or her opinions, it is not surprising that Chinese regard such public speaking as more negative. However, European-American people in the study did not distinguish the two factors and viewed them as a single factor indicating a positive personal quality.

Relatedly, boastfulness is a sign of personal weakness and violates the cautious norm of speaking in East Asia. Learning in Confucian persuasion is geared to counter such personal flaws. Boastfulness is also thought of as narcissistic in Western psychology, in spite of the strong cultural encouragement for self-enhancing speech. Asian-American students have been found less narcissistic and more modest than their European-American peers.⁷⁹ Similarly, college students in Hong Kong are reluctant to ask their professors questions and seek ways to modify the knowledge until they have studied the material and applied it to real life (after practice).⁸⁰ My most recent research also shows that a greater percentage of Chinese words referring to speaking are rated as negative (3.5 times more than positive words) by Chinese college students than English speaking terms referring to speaking are rated as such (1.5 times more) by European-American students.⁸¹ Moreover, we contrasted speaking versus doing and asked Chinese and European-American adults to rate which kind of persons they liked more. Results show that Chinese liked the most a person who talks little but does more (but European-Americans liked the most a person who talks a lot but also does a lot).

Social Concern

Chinese/East Asians carry what might be called a social burden whenever they face speaking in a social setting. Clearly, there are many rules about such speaking in East Asia. In any culture, speaking in social context is a highly delicate social act. But for East Asians, the delicacy lies not in whether to speak, but in how to speak *appropriately* as it is one central teaching of Confucius. Therefore, Chinese/East Asians pay a great deal of attention to it. Such attention and care serve to reduce the amount of thoughtless and random speaking among Asians. Speaking appropriately is a life-long

learning task that starts from childhood and continues through old age. It enables people to achieve their goals, but it can also destroy relationships and cause grave consequences.⁸² Appropriateness hinges on the following two discernable sensitivities: (1) to the particular relationship as part of the social context and (2) to conflict.

Chinese/East Asians are socialized to attend to the specific social role and status of the listener. A set of guidelines for speaking or not speaking is enacted depending on whether the listener/interactant is an authority figure, a family member, a friend, or a stranger. There is no such thing as a general audience, well-educated or not, or an average person on the street as one's listener. Every social interaction is a particular relationship that demands a judgment of how one needs to respond in speaking.⁸³

In general, there are three types of relationships to which one is highly attuned. The first type, as discussed in [Chapters 2 and 5](#), includes the authority figures such as leaders, professors, teachers, parents, and elders toward whom East Asians show deference and respect.⁸⁴ Again, it is erroneous to assume that Asian deference toward authority figures is equal to loss of personal agency to think independently and to challenge them. The issue here is speaking in a way that is appropriate to a given social relationship as required by the culture. One can challenge authority figures without being rude and abrasive. In Asian cultures, speaking appropriately may help one achieve one's goals much better than making a lot of speaking blunders. Accordingly, one usually listens attentively to authority figures, remains humble in posture and countenance, speaks – and especially interrupts – little, but answers questions earnestly. In such relationships, one takes in information and tries to digest well what was said.⁸⁵ When one is asked to offer opinions and suggestions, one is expected to do so readily. Thus, one cannot be unthinking or remain indifferent in such settings. Instead, there is a high demand for one's attentiveness and quick response on the spot. When speaking to a professor, a teacher, or someone who has noted accomplishments, the student or person at a lower level normally use a self-effacing and other-enhancing style such as “in my humble opinion” but “in your wise opinion ...” and “in my unworthy work ...” when preempting one's speech.⁸⁶

In the 1980s, In-Mao Liu⁸⁷ predicted that because Chinese children must learn rules for respect toward authority figures, they are likely to underdevelop self-assertiveness and unlearn it even when they somehow learn it early on, because self-assertiveness clashes with respect. There is a large body of research that verifies this Asian tendency.⁸⁸ For example, Douglas Smith observed that elders in Taiwan spoke much more at the dinner table

than children, while the latter remained attentive.⁸⁹ In an experiment examining assertiveness, Chinese-American students showed a much lower score for the item “asking a professor to clarify a lecture” and ranked it much more difficult than their European-American peers.⁹⁰ The interviews by Kenneth Lieberman showed that many East Asian students attending American universities thought American students disrespectful toward their professors.⁹¹ Finally, my most recent study compared Chinese and European-American college students’ responses to the appropriateness of challenging a professor in class.⁹² The study found that although they approved of such inquisitiveness of students in class, Chinese students questioned the *appropriateness* of students challenging the professor directly in class. They quarreled with the style but not with students’ need to ask questions. They suggested a more acceptable style: seeking the professor out after class to discuss questions and issues face to face rather than making a public scene in class. In contrast, European-American students did not display such distinctions in speaking.

On the other hand, the relationship with the second type of people – peers and people of the same status (e.g., position, age, generation, even coethnicity) – is one that calls for mutuality in communication. In this kind of relationship, after familiarity has been achieved, one is encouraged to speak more freely, openly, and directly.⁹³ Exchange and display of emotions and true feelings are treasured. In fact, Chinese people would find it strange not to engage in such verbal expression with same-status and familiar peers such as relatives, friends, and schoolmates. My own recent research shows that Chinese college students disapprove of peers and siblings who are non-talkative with each other, because there is “no reason for caution and reservation.”⁹⁴

A related attunement for communication is to the context. The most important distinction is inside-versus-outside context, often referred to as in-group versus out-group.⁹⁵ Chinese people’s speaking is differentiated along the line of these two contexts. The speaker needs to know which of the two contexts he or she faces. Within the inside context that includes one’s family, close friends, and social circles, one speaks more openly, freely, and assertively, except toward older generations. The older they are, the more respect is extended toward them. Thus, to a grandmother, children must be deferential in speech (as well as in nonverbal interactions). For example, children need to use the honorific to address her in the second-person pronoun *nin* (您) instead of *ni* (你). Usually, children also address their parents and elders in their parents’ generation (uncles and aunts) with the same honorific, which is audible when the dialect differentiates the sounds (e.g., northern dialects. However, many Chinese dialects do not distinguish

the sounds, but such deference is evident in children's writing). Despite this generational deference, one still talks more openly and assertively and expresses emotions more freely within the inside context including family elders. This is so because Chinese stress life-long ties with these inside people, called "one's own people" (自己人).⁹⁶ One builds a lifelong, dependable, and mutual support system with these people.⁹⁷ Speaking openly with and giving advice (frequently down-to-earth, even hurtful truth) to each other is a sign of the strength of this relationship. Avoidance of such speaking signals weakened ties.⁹⁸ Finally, because coethnics among immigrants are considered an inside context, Paulhus and colleagues found that Asian-heritage college students in Canada are not shy with other Asian-heritage peers (but are more shy when interacting with European-heritage peers, an outside group).⁹⁹

With strangers, the third type of people, also in the outside context, Chinese/East Asians tend to be cautious, avoidant, and reserved, not easily displaying emotions and inner thoughts.¹⁰⁰ East Asians tend to be polite, agreeable, and respectful toward strangers but keep them at a distance. Hence, Chinese/East Asian people find it hard to believe that a stranger whom one just met at a bus stop or only after a brief meeting would call one "my friend" or even "my best friend." Disclosure of personal information such as one's marital status and relationships with parents to strangers is not done among Chinese. Such sharing of personal life only takes place among trusted people. While strangers are part of the outside context, this context includes many types of people who may not necessarily be strangers, such as coworkers and neighbors. To people one does not consider as one's own (外人), one weighs carefully whether to speak or not to speak. Whenever possible, East Asians tend to lean toward silence if they do not have to speak. If they do, they are likely to choose their words with great care, speak more tentatively, less assertively, and even ambiguously on purpose. The key concern is not to make mistakes that can come back to haunt oneself, or to get oneself into a situation that can make oneself vulnerable.¹⁰¹

Beyond the concern for social relationships and contexts, East Asians are especially sensitive toward conflict in communication. For a significant part, their social life is about avoiding conflict. Conflict is a high stress producer because it violates the basic life-orientation of harmony. Conflict leads to embarrassment of the other and self and lingering distress.¹⁰² Speaking up to challenge the other in public, particularly the one in authority and status (e.g., challenging the teacher or professor in class), may be considered deliberate sabotage of the other's face and can result in serious interpersonal consequences. Yet the Chinese social system functions

in such a way that makes it difficult, if at all possible, for one to abandon family ties and other important relationships such as the teacher–student relationship. Therefore, direct confrontation is discouraged and avoided at all costs. When faced with a need to speak, the person is even more attuned to the notion of appropriateness in conflict-laden situations.¹⁰³ For example, when a subordinate disagrees with the supervisor at work, instead of saying something to the effect of “I disagree with you,” “I am uncomfortable with you,” or even “I respectfully disagree with you,” a Chinese/East Asian person is likely to say “I will try my best to see if a slightly different way might work better,” “I heard from XX that this way might . . .,” or “It was my fault not to explain this well to you [even when it is apparent to both the boss and the speaker that the boss is at fault].” Display of strong negative emotions in conflict situations is also discouraged. This is probably why East Asians tend to show no emotion on their face when they are found in conflict.¹⁰⁴ These strategies are common and effective and enable people to achieve their goals and at the same time avoid direct confrontation.

Personal Concern

In light of the preceding discussions of the sensitivities, it is logical that speaking in organized and public settings is also likely to result in greater personal concerns for East Asians. To be blunt, when forced to speak before they are ready, East Asians may experience psychological distress that can take a toll on their socioemotional as well as cognitive functioning.

Several studies have zeroed in on this very topic and have yielded important findings. As noted previously, Chinese-American college students ranked the assertiveness-prone situation of “asking a professor to clarify a lecture” much more difficult than their European-American peers.¹⁰⁵ East Asian Canadian college students were found to feel significantly more anxious and guilty following assertive responding (e.g., telling a friend who calls frequently about her relationship issues not to call so often because one is too busy) than European Canadians. This Asian tendency is especially relevant to acquaintances but not to strangers.¹⁰⁶ In another study, significantly more recent East Asian immigrant Canadians reported to feel shy in class (91 percent) than European Canadians (51 percent). And the most frequent reason for their shyness was “fear of being wrong” for Asian Canadians (30 percent), compared to 5 percent for European Canadians.¹⁰⁷ Finally, Heejung Kim studied how East Asians and East Asian Americans view speaking as a cognitive function in comparison with European-American college students.¹⁰⁸ She found that whereas European-American

students believed that speaking enhances thinking, East Asians believed the opposite effect of speaking. Her experiments examining performing cognitive tasks in silence versus talking aloud demonstrated that whereas speaking did not interfere with and even enhanced European-American students' performance, it did interfere with Asian students' performance. Her further study shows that having to speak while trying to solve problems not only reduced Asian students' performance (more recent immigrants), but also caused higher stress in them as measured in cortisol levels (but verbalization benefitted European-American students performance and relaxed instead of stressing them).

These research findings compel us to conclude that there are indeed very large differences in speaking between the two cultures. The three important concerns that East Asians carry with them may serve to reduce the amount of speaking among East Asians and to shape how they speak in social settings and in learning.

EAST ASIAN SPEAKING STYLE

The preceding sections discussed the Chinese/East Asian cultural tradition of speaking and concerns people may have when faced with the need to speak. In what follows, I discuss the speaking style of Chinese/East Asians. Similar to the four Gricean maxims governing Western people's speaking style, there seem to be four different maxims guiding Chinese/East Asians when they do speak.

The Maxim of Paucity: Speak Little

As previously discussed, the default for the Chinese/East Asian mode is not to speak if there is no need. Volunteering to speak without a need may be regarded as inappropriate or insensitive to a setting, not to mention making unnecessary promises when one is not prepared to back them up with action. Speaking little is very different from the Western maxim, "Speak no more and no less," which stresses the need for the speaker to calculate the *right amount* of speaking as required by the conversation. This maxim still presumes a speaking mode. It is just that the speaker needs to adhere to the right quantity. Unlike this Western maxim, paucity in speaking is a virtue, preferred and valued, for Chinese/East Asians as noted before.

Paucity in speaking may even be a sign of intelligence in Asia. Research conducted by Shih-Ying Yang and Robert Sternberg found that Taiwanese people regarded an intelligent person as one who knows "when to assert

him/herself and when to draw back” beyond other common attributes of intelligence such as having a quick mind.¹⁰⁹ However, verbal fluency was one of the primary definitional attributes of intelligence in the West. Certainly, knowing when *not* to speak was not part of the definition.¹¹⁰ In Japan, talkativeness is considered superficial and unintelligent.¹¹¹ This is probably why Judge Bao in court did not speak much either. Given the positive image of the reluctance to speak, there is little wonder why East Asians have been observed across time and space as more reserved in speaking.

When they do decide to speak, Chinese/East Asians do so more likely in two ways. The first way is to speak slowly, cautiously, hesitantly, and self-effacingly.¹¹² Such a style signals to the listener that the speaker is well aware of the liabilities of speaking, is willing to revise what he or she has spoken about, and is not ready to commit him- or herself to the expected action. The second way is to speak with assurance and certainty but still with reservation and less assertiveness. This style indicates that the speaker has a responsibility for and command over the topic or the issue and is ready to back up the spoken ideas with action. Because such speech conveys assurance, the listener is likely to take the speaker up on the ideas and suggestions.

In learning, the student is also guided by these two ways of speaking. Because the student is supposed to seek the teacher's guidance with a humble attitude and receptivity, the student may have a greater need to be hesitant, cautious, and self-effacing. In East Asian cultures, such a speaking style, coupled with the need to show respect to teachers, makes Asian learners appear docile and passive to the non-Asian eye. The following example illustrates the case in point well: several years ago, a European-American colleague and I went to a rural area in China to collect data on children's conceptions of teaching and learning. Although these children had never seen a real European-American, they did interact with my colleague one on one, as requested and encouraged by us and their teachers. One by one, these children followed our instructions and completed the research tasks. But my colleague observed that these children did not initiate any contact with him, particularly did not verbalize much in front of him; they stood straight and just did what they were told. However, when they worked with each other, they whispered and gestured to each other rather than speaking audibly. After being puzzled about these children for four weeks, my colleague finally asked me why Chinese children were not talking and appeared not even very lively to him. I pointed out that the same speechless and “unlively” children would become loud and rambunctious in their own yards. Indeed, my colleague saw the difference of behavior and made

an insightful comment about his discovery: “[T]hen this is a sign of intelligence because these very young children are able to differentiate and conduct themselves according to different social contexts!”

The Maxim of Ambiguity: Speak Indeterminately

East Asians are known for speaking with circumlocution and vagueness. Ambiguity in communication is common.¹¹³ This stands in sharp contrast to the Western maxim of speaking clarity. Western people may find this style difficult to deal with, but East Asians may find the Western style equally hard to adjust to. As Agnes He points out, the Asian style of ambiguity is not semantic or logical failure, but a preference.¹¹⁴ Hui-Ching Chang in her studies of Chinese daily communication also came to the same conclusion, namely that Chinese thrive on the style that fits their need to maintain the social system with clearly defined roles, but at the same time that fits their need to keep a space for communicative indeterminacy.¹¹⁵ This flexible space between their fixed roles (e.g., parental or child role) and the vagaries of daily life allows them to be creative in achieving their goals. Mastery of this style may generate high regard from people and surely requires much learning and understanding.

This particular style may owe its origin to Taoism as a philosophy of dialectics. Taoism claims that the universe consists of two fundamental forces: yin and yang, the feminine for the former and the masculine for the latter. However, yin and yang complement each other and coexist at all times. Moreover, these two forces are never fixed and stable, but always in flux. Their changing nature is the principle according to which the universe operates. As illustrated in the yin-yang symbol, the universe is oneness with infinite dynamics for change (Figure 8.1). The visual depiction of this dynamic oneness is diagrammed as a perfect circle divided into a white fish next to the identically shaped but opposite-positioned black fish. The tail of the white fish is adjacent to the head of the black fish. Both the body contours and the lines of the two fish are fluid, indicating their potentiality of morphing into each other. Thus, the seeming opposite of the most basic forces of the universe, visualized as white and black, is not opposite at all. Each pole of existence in this philosophy is the beginning dynamic of the other. When the dynamic reaches the other pole, it becomes the other and at the same time begins to return to the original state. Life recycles ceaselessly in yin and yang.

Such is the world in which East Asians have been living for millennia. This way of viewing and living the world is so natural to them that their



FIGURE 8.1. The yin-yang symbol.

food, music, dance, arts, sports, medicine, even science (e.g., agriculture and hydraulic engineering), and personal creativity are all influenced by this worldview. Because the world is believed to always change, there is no point of seeing any one thing as fixed eternally. Kaiping Peng and Richard Nisbett have investigated this topic in East Asian and Western thinking and have found large, consistent differences in their beliefs.¹¹⁶ Western people view the world by following three laws of logic: (1) identity (e.g., the statement “a teacher is a teacher” is true because of the identical names of both sides), (2) noncontradiction (i.e., if something is A, it cannot be not-A), and (3) the excluded middle (i.e., if A is true, it cannot be false; there is no middle term to which these contradictions belong). But Taoism holds three different principles: (1) constant changes (e.g., A is A only now, but A can become X and thus no longer be A), (2) contradiction (e.g., A can be not-A depending on the context and perspective of the viewer), and (3) holism or interconnectivity of all things (i.e., A, B, ... *n* are all connected so that A can be part of B ... *n* and vice versa). All three principles are clearly illustrated in the yin-yang diagram. These researchers have done many studies showing that East Asian and Western people perceive differently even the most basic objects such as a triangle made of wood or clay, as well as basic relationship such as a larger fish among smaller fish or a green pencil in a group of red pencils. Whereas Western people view things in sharp distinctions, East Asians see more background as part of any single object or see all elements more relationally.

Living with such a perspective of life enables East Asians to be tolerant toward, comfortable with, expectant of, and even embracing change, contradiction, and interconnectivity of things in life. In other words, to

them, ambiguity is but a norm in life. Speaking ambiguously is thus natural. Because speaking and listening require each other as cultural cooperation, East Asians are equally adept at listening to ambiguity. Speaking too clearly and sharply may bewilder them and generate discomfort. It is not an exaggeration to say that figuring out ambiguity in communication is not merely socially necessary, but also intellectually challenging, highly motivating, even fun at times.

East Asians use ambiguity in speech to accomplish many goals. I highlight two common ones here. As many scholars have pointed out, East Asians' speaking leaves much greater room for interpretation in order to achieve their goals.¹¹⁷ For example, in class, a teacher sees a student talk to a peer, not paying attention to her instruction. Instead of calling out the student's name, which would embarrass the student, the teacher may say, "There are people seeking others out to talk" (有人找別人講話). In fact, in Chinese, the quantity in the phrase "there are people" (有人) is not linguistically marked (owing to lack of morphology for quantity in Chinese). For the whole class, it is not clear whom the teacher is referring to – a particular peer, oneself, or everyone. Hearing this teacher comment, all children become more attentive to the class. The child who actually sought out another to chat is likely to stop. As observed by Agnes He in Chinese language classes, this strategy of speaking is commonly used by teachers to achieve disciplinary results.¹¹⁸ It is worth noting that no student would demand clarity in such a situation. Ambiguous speech is appropriately delivered by the teacher and accepted cooperatively by students.

When one is not sure about one's response or if one's response might usher in unwanted consequences, one may use ambiguous speech to manage the situation. For example, the chair of school department is asked when a decision will be made regarding the hiring of a new teacher. Instead of giving some reference to a time (e.g., a week or as soon as possible, which is a more typical response in the West), the chair can say, "We will let you know when we get to that point." This kind of responding serves to create indeterminacy. It signals to the listener that the chair is working on the issue, no definite answer is available, and pressing the chair for a definite answer at this point may be inappropriate. An East Asian questioner is less likely to demand a definite answer again. Such a strategy is also used in the West and other cultures, but in East Asia it represents a routine way of speaking.

The Maxim of Indirectness: Speak Amicably

This maxim rests on the very high value of *harmony* in East Asian cultures. As discussed earlier, East Asians do not like confrontation and conflict,

particularly regarding interpersonal relationships.¹¹⁹ Their interactive principles are regulated by the role each person occupies. An authority role requires respect that comes with specific speech and behavior. A subordinate or a person at a younger age or in a younger generation also needs to speak within the acceptable *li* (ritual propriety). Harmony happens when the speaker and the listener uphold the same principles and honor each other's roles. Speaking out of one's role and relationship is something that East Asians would like to avoid.¹²⁰

However, disagreement and conflict are unavoidable in life. When they happen, East Asians become highly sensitive to a principle to which they adhere: "give others face."¹²¹ This basic style is to watch out not to cause embarrassment or, worse, shame in the other. Speaking that manages to avoid embarrassment and to honor the other is considered an important interpersonal skill. Insensitive and malicious speaking that causes people to lose face is a serious offense. Lost face or "broken face" (撕破脸) often results in termination of a relationship (e.g., friends turning into enemies), family feud, and even physical violence.

Thus, when speaking, Chinese/East Asians prefer an unassertive style. They use indirect speech to achieve many goals. For example, a student is not sure how her professor thinks of her, but she would like to ask for a recommendation letter. So, instead of saying directly to the professor, "Would you be willing to write a letter on my behalf?" she would say, "I wonder how professors write recommendations letters for students." In the East Asian context, a professor is probably alerted to an upcoming request from the student. In reply, the professor can say, "Well, usually professors write letters for students who show good learning attitude, work hard, and do well." The student then can say, "I guess I need to improve myself in these regards." If the professor thinks well of the student, he might offer, "I think you were a good student in my class." By speaking indirectly, the student avoided a potentially embarrassing situation for both her and the professor if the latter did not think well of her. But with her indirect approach, she obtained the desired information and is likely to succeed in getting a recommendation letter.

Chang studied how people in Taiwan use indirect speech to create space in their defined roles for negotiating their relational status.¹²² She observed a mother-in-law who wanted her son to drive her and her husband to a department store. But she was not sure that she would succeed, given the difficult relationship with her daughter-in-law. The mother-in-law said: "We are going to the department store. We'd better take the bus and take our time getting there." Upon hearing this nondemanding expression, the daughter-in-law, in trying to fulfill her filial duty, replied "Mom, why do

you need to take a bus? We'll take you there." The mother-in-law is masterful in using indirect speech and managed to give the daughter-in-law a chance to be kind and at the same time to achieve her goal of being taken to the store.

On the negative side, I observed a bilingual research assistant who was caught between the two cultures' communication styles. This assistant is of Chinese heritage but grew up in the United States. She is a straight-A student and a caring person. By Western standard, she is very sharp, speaks clearly, and gets her message across efficiently. Her task was to interview Chinese immigrant parents who were born and raised outside the United States. Therefore, she spoke Chinese to these parents. One of the areas that Chinese/East Asian people consider to be private is their marital status. Typically, when experienced interviewers ask such a question about a mother's marital status, they speak cautiously, interjecting many fillers such as "hm, hm..., uh, uh..., I apologize, I regrettably request for ..." as if they were stuttering and stammering. These fillers serve to soften the tone and show hesitation, making something direct sound indirect. They convey to the listener that the speaker is kind, caring, feels bad to have to ask such a question, in order to ensure smooth communication. Sharpness and directness are the wrong style, to be avoided at all costs. Because the assistant was interviewing these parents on the phone for the first time, she was a stranger to them (which demands even more indirect speech for such a private topic). Unfortunately, she asked the question sharply, directly, and efficiently (as written on the questionnaire). Quite a number of mothers were offended by the manner in which she asked her questions. They questioned if she was with the police and told her that they were very uncomfortable with her way of speaking, despite the fact that she spoke linguistically perfect Chinese. Some even wanted to quit their participation in the research on the spot.

As these examples illustrate, indirect verbal interaction is of key importance in Chinese/East Asian lives. Direct speech stands to hurt and worsen relationships, but skillfully expressed indirect speech can help build and strengthen relationships as well as heal and repair strained ones.

The Maxim of Listenership: Listening before Speaking

In their insightful analysis of the Taiwanese parent-child narratives, Heidi Fung and Peggy Miller showed how listening is not passive but *active* in parent-child communications.¹²³ Unlike their European-American peers, Taiwanese children listen attentively; they do not use the typically Western style of argument to interact with their caregivers. Only after they listen

carefully do Taiwanese children interject responses and even voice challenges to adults' instructions and actions. Although other scholars have identified the East Asian style as listener-centered as opposed to speaker-centered,¹²⁴ it was Fung and Miller who articulated the active nature of listening for East Asians and backed the observation with empirical data. Based on their and others' research, it is clear that East Asia *privileges* listening (emphasizing listenership) whereas the West *privileges* speaking (emphasizing speakership) because it is a matter of choice and preference. Viewing the East Asian style as some kind of deficiency or a problem is not conducive to our understanding.

East Asians' need to listen well is a natural component of the other three maxims of speaking as discussed previously. Because the style of speaking emphasizes little talk, silence, ambiguity, and indirectness, the interlocutor has to do a lot more work in listening in order to decipher the full meaning of what is spoken about. From available analysis, it seems that Chinese/East Asian listeners make three kinds of effort when following the maxim of listenership: (1) figure out "fine and hidden" meanings, (2) extend, if deeming desirable, the unexpressed but intended by the speaker, and (3) interject speaking at the right moment in the right context.

Gao observes that in communication, Chinese people need to figure out "fine and hidden meanings"¹²⁵ from the speaker before they can respond. At least in Chinese, there are many sayings acknowledging the need and demand on the listener: for example, "not saying all that is felt" (言外之意), "more is meant than meets the ear" (只可會意, 不可言傳), "meaning lies beyond words" (意在言外), and "meaning lies in the unspoken" (意在不言之中). It is expected that the listener will be sensitive to and endeavor to decipher the intended but unexpressed meanings. I would add that it is also the Chinese artistic and aesthetic philosophy to create art works (e.g., poems, paintings, architecture, and other visual forms) according to the same suggestive but not exhaustively expressive style. Aphorisms such as "words have ended, but meaning is infinite" (言已盡, 而意無窮) and "at this moment, it's better to have silence than sound" (此處無聲勝有聲) convey this principle.¹²⁶

Thus, the listener needs to "examine a person's words and observe his/her countenance" (察言觀色)¹²⁷ by drawing meanings from linking "what is said to personal experiences (體會) and "to contemplate/ponder" (琢磨).¹²⁸ Such work on listening is likely to lead the person to recover the fuller meaning of the spoken words and to respond more appropriately.

When the listener has gained a fuller understanding of the spoken words, he/she may engage in the second kind of effort: extending the unexpressed

but intended meaning by the speaker, if such an extension is deemed desirable and appropriate. This kind of extension is well illustrated by the student Zigong's conversation with Confucius (quoted already in [Chapter 6](#) but repeated here for ease of reference):

ZIGONG SAID: "What do you think of the saying: 'Poor but not inferior; rich but not superior'?" The Master replied: "Not bad, but not as good as: 'Poor but enjoying the way (*dao*, 道), rich but loving ritual propriety (*li*, 禮)"

ZIGONG SAID: "*The Book of Songs* states:

Like bone carved and polished,

Like jade cut and ground.

Is this not what you have in mind?"

THE MASTER SAID: "Zigong, it is only with the likes of you then that I can discuss the *Songs*! On the basis of what has been said, you know what is yet to come."¹²⁹

Here, what impressed Confucius was that Zigong not only understood the teacher's alerting him to be humble and urging him to strive further in his self-cultivation, but also *extended* the meaning implied by Confucius: Students need to bounce off each other's ideas and understanding like bone being carved and polished, like jade being cut and ground. Only this way can students go deeper in their learning. Zigong's connecting what his teacher said to the highly cherished *Book of Songs* adds further testimony of him being a very attentive listener and dedicated learner, thus earning Confucius' praise.

The third effort of the listener is to interject speaking at the right moment in the right context. Learning how to time one's interjection is key. Interjection in this manner includes comments, questioning, disagreements, even challenges. Here, Fung, Miller, and Lin provide a telling example¹³⁰: Angu, a four-year-old Taiwanese girl, was being reprimanded by her aunt, the caregiver, for her misdeeds of spilling food, misbehaving at the table, and dashing into and kicking dishes (breaking them and endangering herself). As a common socializing effort, Taiwanese parents routinely recount these daily mishaps to the child and other family members. In the process, the child is cast as the focal actor but also the listener of the story about herself (along with other listeners), with the misdeeds highlighted. The child's role is first to listen attentively and then to respond when questioned and taught for better future behavior. For the unfamiliar eye, East Asian parents are just authoritarian and disciplinarian, not allowing the child a chance to defend herself. Fung and colleagues' data show a much more dynamic and nuanced picture. Angu listened to her aunt's harangue for more than ten minutes, patiently waiting for her aunt to calm down. Then she began

her challenge by saying "I am asking you a question." Angu asked why her aunt was unreasonable with her (yelling). When her aunt pressed her why she did not know how to walk carefully around the dishes, Angu replied, "because I fell." Angu then threw the question at her aunt: "Why did you not reason with me nicely?" She went on to question her aunt if the latter made any mistakes when she herself was a child. When the aunt tried to fend off Angu by saying that she was a well-behaved child and never spilled food, Angu called her grandmother to verify her aunt's claim of herself being a perfect child.

This example illustrates vividly how listening is not just an end in and of itself, but a requirement for further verbal (or nonverbal) social interaction. East Asian children indeed are expected to listen more than to speak in a situation where adults clearly have more authority (correcting the child's transgressions). However, children also learn that they can interject at the right moment in the right context in order to express their own ideas, even to challenge the authority; they do so without engaging in the immediate verbal argument, but by listening fully first.

EAST ASIAN CLASSROOM DISCOURSE AND SOCIALIZATION

All the sensitivities to and the four maxims of speaking are taught and practiced in the classroom as the major socialization context outside of home. First, as Agnes He noted in her informative analysis, neither ideas – as in the case of correct answers and thoughtful comments by students – nor their wrong answers and less impressive expressions are attributed to children as owners/authors by Chinese teachers.¹³¹ Instead, teachers focus on the *content* of what needs to be learned. She gave several examples where the teacher elicited children's responses on how to write Chinese characters or their opinions about a story. There was plenty of ambiguity regarding who made a better or weaker suggestion, who deserved the credit for an idea, who disagreed with whom, and so on to be cleared by the teacher. However, the teacher did not even attempt to do so, nor did the children request/demand such clarification. Instead, they discussed what the correct writing of Chinese characters was and then moved on to the next learning task. In the case of discussing responses to a story, the teacher collected the various responses from students but without singling out any individual student. The same pattern has been found by many researchers in their observations of classrooms in China and Hong Kong.¹³²

Another vivid example was captured by Yeh Hsueh in his video study on a day at the Chinese preschool in Beijing.¹³³ In the video, there is a scene

where the teacher holds, as a daily routine, a reading session with every child looking at a book. Children's reading is guided by the teacher's questions. When she asked, "What is the elephant doing?" many hands went up. She picked a child, who stood up and answered the question correctly. The teacher then asked her to sit down without a single word of affirmation or praise and moved on to the next question.

Such focus on the learning content rather than on the ownership/authorship of individuals' ideas practically eliminates the potentially adverse effect of students' social comparison on each other. This style may underlie the common practice of calling students to display their misunderstanding or weak skills publicly (on the blackboard or just sharing with the class verbally). According to recorded proceedings of classroom teaching, children do not show discomfort with this display of their errors.¹³⁴ As noted in [Chapter 3](#), when the self is regarded as malleable and improvable through learning, children know that a mistake does not indicate an inherent flaw in themselves, but rather an opportunity to self-improve. This kind of classroom teaching is based on the belief that asserting the self verbally is unimportant in the process of learning. What is important is the focus on the improvable nature of oneself. Since ascertaining the moment-to-moment quality of the self is not ever the focus, authoring oneself through speech becomes trivial, if not discouraged altogether.

The preceding discussion may give the impression that Chinese classrooms are passive, which has been the indictment against East Asian education.¹³⁵ However, the indictment may operate on the assumption that active engagement in learning has only one manifestation: verbalization. Not verbalizing then is passive learning. This may be a strong Western assumption and practice, but it may not hold true for East Asian learners.

Closer examination reveals that speaking little does not mean that Chinese/East Asians are uninvolved. Quite the contrary, East Asians' little speaking/silence is evidence that they are highly sensitive and attentive to the situation. As alluded to previously, in settings where one finds oneself in need of speaking little or remaining silent, one pays more, not less, attention to the speaker. For example, it is repeatedly observed that in East Asian classrooms, children show rapt attention even when the teacher does not seem, to the outside eye, that engaging.¹³⁶ Pupils often respond to the teacher's question by responding in unison if the answer is definite or elicited by a rhetorical question such as "how much is 5×6 ?" For open-ended questions, pupils are called on to respond. Being ready to respond and respond well is taken as a sign of student engagement and a good learning attitude. Lack of such readiness is cause for concern for parents and teachers. Apparently,

Chinese/East Asian children's rapt attention and participation are not conditioned by their need to speak very much.¹³⁷

Research on Japanese classrooms shows a very high level of participation and active thinking. Despite little verbalization, students' journals and other written work were full of questions, puzzlements, even disputes with their peers who did speak. Such a form, common in Asian schools, is even dubbed as "silent participation" by Inagaki, Hatano, and Morita.¹³⁸ The same pattern is also found in Chinese classrooms. Cortazzi and Jin give two responses by Chinese students, one from an elementary school child and the other from a Chinese student at a British university:

I may be listening but I am not passive. I am learning in my head. I learn from my teacher. I also learn from what my friends do. If they make a mistake, I learn from that too.

We are active in our minds. We are thinking all the time. Our minds follow the lecturer with questions and challenges. We are just not used to speaking out. But all of us know very well what is going on and we know the answers to the questions those lecturers asked or other students raised.¹³⁹

These testimonies from students themselves, as well as independent observations, confirm this active nature of learning, which does not depend on momentary verbalization, but rather on attentive listening. Such listening is likely to generate more thoughtful verbal responses at a later time. This focus on listening in Chinese classrooms led Cortazzi and Jin to dub the style as "listening-oriented learning."¹⁴⁰

GROWING UP A RELUCTANT SPEAKER

As already alluded to in the previous section, home is the fertile nursery for cultural transmission of values and norms pertaining to speaking (along with other values). Values that parents uphold may be spoken about, enacted, and modeled frequently and forcefully. Ideas and behaviors that are not valued or even rejected by parents are handled with aversion, vagueness, or ignored altogether. In general, research finds that early on, Japanese mothers are less verbal with their infants, and their children produce significantly fewer utterances per turn than their European-American counterparts.¹⁴¹ Likewise, Chinese babies vocalize less than European-American babies to respond to laboratory tasks, and this trend continues in adulthood.¹⁴² On a more ethnographic account, Douglas Smith observed Taiwanese children speaking little but listening very attentively to adults talking at a dinner table.¹⁴³

To peek into the actual process of socialization for reluctant speaking, I provide two examples of my own research: My colleague and I asked rural Chinese mothers to teach their children a new household chore. A mother said very little but gestured to her preschool child (usually surrounded by a group of curious neighborhood children) to indicate a task such as peeling vegetables. First, the mother demonstrated how to peel the vegetable in slow motion. Then, she handed a half-peeled vegetable to the child for her to continue. After some hand-holding and a few gentle corrections, the child succeeded in learning the skill. When successful, the child smiled and the mother made some sound, indicating that the child could go out to play. There was no praise at all. Children seemed to carry out their daily routines without expectation of parental praise for anything they did. But we observed a boy who, after learning a similar skill, uttered, "Oh, that was too easy!" showing off his achievement. Upon hearing this reaction to his success, the mother broke her nonverbal mode: "You are so full of yourself!" and "Are you also like that in school?" Without any reply, but turning away, the boy ran out to play with other children.

Notice who talked and who did not in this exchange. The one who was motivated to call attention to his achievement in front of the other children – the boy and the learner – spoke first. By contrast, the one who actually had a skill to teach – the mother – spoke little. Instead, she acted her teaching out by demonstrating, simplifying, and correcting with gestures, much like Judge Bao in his court. When the mother chided her child for showing off his achievement (our post-teaching interview revealed that the mother regarded this learning too trivial for her boy to display such pride in public), the initially proud child became silent, exiting the scene quickly. Nonverbal teaching and learning proceeded smoothly and successfully until there was a need to speak. Unfortunately, the boy's need to speak did not fit the cultural norm for humility when facing one's own achievement (particularly trivial for household chores). This lack of virtue as cherished in Chinese culture was surely cause for the mother to speak to the child. By remaining silent and exiting the scene, the child showed receptivity to his mother's teaching. By speaking as her parenting duty required, the mother achieved her goal of teaching humility. What is more interesting was that other children also stood there silently in this whole episode, with rapt attention. They also learned by watching this adult-child teaching and learning interaction attentively. They knew that it was not their place to speak either, as it was likely to be a repeated experience for them with their own parents at home.

Nevertheless, the four-year-old Taiwanese girl who listened carefully and patiently and then seized the right moment to challenge her aunt is also responded to by adults with due respect. Her aunt did not shut her up – in fact, she did not even criticize her for speaking up. Instead, she became a defendant by claiming to be a good young child herself. These examples illustrate that Chinese/East Asians' choice and preference to speak or not to speak are a matter of great sensitivity, sensibility, and skill to be cultivated in their culture. Unfortunately, in cross-cultural contexts of learning, the Chinese/East Asian reluctance to speak is often taken as lack of thought, disengagement, verbal ineptness, worse yet, inscrutableness, character flaw, or point-blank dishonesty. Not only does this view miss the point, but it breeds mistrust and causes harm to children and students from East Asian cultural backgrounds.

NOTES

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2. See note 61 to Chapter 3.
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5. Katriel, T., & Philipsen, G. (1981). “What we need is communication:” “Communication” as a cultural category in some American speech. *Communication Monographs*, 48, 301–317.
6. The whole psychotherapy as a healing process is predicated on the assumption that verbalizing one's memories, experiences, thoughts, and emotions is a process from mental illness to mental health. See Petrie, K. J., Booth, R. J., Pennebaker, J. W., & Davison, K. P. (1995). Disclosure of trauma and immune response to a hepatitis B vaccination program. *Journal of Counseling and Clinical Psychology*, 63, 787–792; and Frattaroli, J. (2006). Experimental disclosure and its moderators: A metaanalysis. *Psychological Bulletin*, 132, 823–865 for research and review of this topic.
7. See note 24 to Chapter 4.
8. Paulhus, D. L., & Morgan, K. L. (1997). Perceptions of intelligence in leaderless groups: Dynamic effects of shyness and acquaintance. *Journal of Personality*

- and *Social Psychology*, 72, 581–591; Cheek, J. M., & Buss, A. H. (1981). Shyness and sociability. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 41, 330–339; Jones, W. H., & Carpenter, B. N. (1986). Shyness, social behavior and relations. In W. H. Jones, J. M. Cheek, & S. R. Briggs (Eds.), *Shyness: Perspectives on research and treatment* (pp. 227–238). New York: Plenum; and Traub, G. S. (1983). Correlations of shyness with depression, anxiety, and academic performance. *Psychological Reports*, 52, 849–850.
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 12. See note 56 to Chapter 6, p. 188.
 13. Aeschylus (1996). *The Oresteia trilogy: Agamemnon, the Libation-Bearers and the Furies*. Mineola, NY: Dover.
 14. Cooper, C. (2004). *Sights and sounds of the Athenian Court*. New York: Routledge.
 15. Gluckman, M. (2006). *Politics, law and ritual in tribal society*. Piscataway, NJ: Aldine Transaction.
 16. Li, X.-D., Sun, W.-Q., & Luo, G.-Z. (2010). 李行道孙文卿罗贯中集 [Collection of Li Xingdao, Sun Wenqing, and Luo Guanzhong]. Shangxi: People's Publishing House.
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 20. Cowell, F. R. (1973). *Cicero and the Roman Republic* (5th ed.). New York: Penguin.
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 27. I am grateful to Becca Goldstein for sharing the Jewish tradition with me and for pointing to the reference of Fox, S., Scheffler, I., & Marom, D. (Eds.). (2003). *Visions of Jewish education*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

28. For example, the university where I teach does not have enough course offerings to freshmen and sophomores, frequently even juniors. Students have to wait until their senior year to get into a public speaking course.
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32. See the third reference in note 31 to this chapter; and Lee, K., Xu, F., Fu, G., Cameron, C. A., & Chen, S. (2001). Taiwan and Mainland Chinese and Canadian children's categorization and evaluation of lie- and truth-telling: A modest effect. *British Journal of Developmental Psychology*, 19, 525–542.
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35. See the first reference in note 31 to this chapter.
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39. See note 38 to this chapter; note 14 to Chapter 4; and Webb, N. M., Franke, M. L., Ing, M., Chan, A., De. T., Freund, D. et al. (2008). The role of teacher instructional practices in student collaborations. *Contemporary Educational Psychology*, 33, 360–381.
40. Hewitt, R., & Inghilleri, M. (1993). Oracy in the Classroom: Policy, pedagogy, and group oral work. *Anthropology & Education Quarterly*, 24(4), 308–317, p. 310. Also see Lisa Delpit calls this learning mastery of the “code of power” in Delpit, L. D. (1995). *Other people's children: Cultural conflict in the classroom*. New York: The New Press.

41. See Tobin, J., Hsueh, Y., & Karasawa, M. (2009). *Preschool in three cultures revisited: China, Japan, and United States*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press for vivid examples in American preschools.
42. See the first reference in note 40 and the last reference in note 38 to this chapter.
43. Interestingly, both White and Afro-Caribbean children were keenly aware that the kind of oracy they were learning in school requiring disagreement and argumentation about a topic was separate from their real-life talk where cooperation and agreement reigned. Even after their formal debate in class, the children would try to “repair” their disagreement and resume the “cooperative” imperative that governed their verbal interaction outside of school.
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47. See note 44 to this chapter, p. 322.
48. See note 44 to this chapter, p. 327.
49. Caudhill, W., & Weinstein, H. (1969). Maternal care and infant behavior in Japan and America. *Psychiatry*, 32, 12–43; Minami, M. (1994). English and Japanese: A cross-cultural comparison parental styles of narrative elicitation. *Issues in Applied Linguistics*, 5, 383–407; and Murase, T., Dale, P. S., Ogura, T., Yamashita, Y., & Mahieu, A. (2005). Mother–child conversation during joint picture book reading in Japan and the USA. *First Language*, 25, 197–218.
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52. See note 6 to Chapter 7; and the third and fourth references in note 7 to Chapter 7.
53. See note 74 to Chapter 2.
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55. See note 79 to Chapter 2.
56. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 1.3.
57. Xu, G. Q. (2004). The use of eloquence: The Confucian perspective. In C. S. Lipson & R. A. Binkley (Eds.), *Rhetoric before and beyond the Greeks* (pp. 115–130). Albany: State University of New York Press, p. 118.
58. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 16.1 and 15.11.
59. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 17.18.
60. See note 79 to Chapter 2, p. 16.
61. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 16.5.
62. “Chariots” is a reference to the size of a state during the Spring and Autumn and Warring State periods (722–221 BCE). A chariot is a military vehicle with

- four horses and three soldiers. "A thousand chariots" indicates a midsize state. Retrieved November 5, 2010 from <http://www.cxgjdq.com/cy/ZmZzZm8.html>
63. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 11.26.
 64. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 11.26.
 65. See note 5 to Chapter 2, pp. 46–48. The authors argue that *Heaven* as a traditional translation of *tian* is inaccurate because *Heaven* denotes the Judeo-Christian concept, but this is not the meaning by *tian*. They decided not to translate this term for *the Analects*. I concur with the authors but have chosen to use *Heaven* here for convenience.
 66. See note 62 to Chapter 2. Jin Li's translation.
 67. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 17.19.
 68. See note 5 to Chapter 2, p. 122.
 69. Lyon, A. (2004). Confucian silence and remonstrance: A basis for deliberation? In C. S. Lipson & R. A. Binkley (Eds.), *Rhetoric before and beyond the Greeks* (pp. 131–145). Albany: State University of New York Press, p. 137.
 70. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 2.13, 4.24, and 4.22. Also see 14.27, 1.14, 12.3, and 13.20.
 71. See note 69 to this chapter.
 72. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 12.1.
 73. See note 5 to Chapter 2, 8.4, 16.6, and 10.1.
 74. See note 69 to this chapter, p. 136.
 75. See note 69 to this chapter, pp. 136–137.
 76. See the first reference in note 75 to Chapter 2; and Ishii, S., & Bruneau, T. (1994). Silence and silences in cross-cultural perspective: Japan and the United States. In L. A. Samovar & R. E. Porter (Eds.), *Intercultural communication: A reader* (7th ed.) (pp. 246–251). Belmont, CA: Wadsworth for valued silence in contemporary Japanese culture.
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 78. See note 91 to Chapter 6.
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 83. See the Introduction to the *Analects of Confucius* in note 5 to Chapter 2.
 84. See reference in note 47 to Chapter 2.
 85. More detailed discussion on Asian listenership in later sections.
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88. See, for example, the second and third references in note 4 to this chapter.
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91. Liberman, K. (1994). Asian student perspectives on American University instruction. *International Journal of Intercultural Relations*, 18, 173–192. Also see Liu, J. (2002). Negotiating silence in American classrooms: Three Chinese cases. *Language and intercultural communication*, 2(1), 37–54 for Chinese graduate students' showing respect toward professors by not speaking in U.S. classrooms.
92. See note 81 to this chapter.
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94. See note 81 to this chapter.
95. Triandis, H. C. (1995). *Individualism and collectivism*. Boulder, CO: Westview.
96. See the first reference in note 82 to this chapter and Yang, Y.-Y. (2001). '自己人': 一項有關中國人關係分類的個案研究 [‘One of us’: A case study on the classification of Chinese guanxi]. *Indigenous Psychological Research in Chinese Societies*, 13, 277–316.
97. See the third reference in note 1 to Chapter 2.
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99. See note 3 to this chapter.
100. See note 93 to this chapter.
101. See the first reference in note 82 to this chapter.
102. See the second reference in note 51 to Chapter 2; note 93 to this chapter; Ting-Toomey, S. (Ed.) (1994). *The challenge of facework: Cross-cultural and interpersonal issues*. Albany: State University of New York Press; and Gao, G. (1998b). An initial analysis of the effects of face and concern for “other” in Chinese interpersonal communication. *International Journal of Intercultural Relations*, 22(4), 467–482.
103. See note 80 to Chapter 2; and the second reference in note 82 to this chapter.
104. See the first reference in note 82 to this chapter.
105. See note 90 to this chapter.
106. See note 93 to this chapter.
107. See note 3 to this chapter.
108. See note 60 to Chapter 4; and Kim, H. S. (2008). Culture and the cognitive and neuroendocrine responses to speech. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 94 (1), 32–47.
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110. See note 24 to Chapter 4.
111. See the second reference in note 76 to this chapter; the second reference in note 80 to Chapter 2; and Azuma, H. (1986). Why study child development in Japan? In H. Stevenson, H. Azuma, & K. Hakuta (Eds.), *Child development and education in Japan* (pp. 3–12). New York: Freeman.
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113. See note 112 to this chapter.
114. See note 10 to this chapter.
115. See the second reference in note 82 to this chapter.
116. See the first reference in note 29 to Chapter 2; and note 53 to Chapter 5.
117. See notes 33 and 77 to this chapter.
118. See note 10 to this chapter.
119. See the fourth references in note 102 to this chapter; the third reference in note 112 to this chapter; and Young, L. W. L. (1994). *Crosstalk and culture in Sino-American communication*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
120. See note 82 to this chapter.
121. See the first reference in note 82 to this chapter, p. 180. In the third reference in note 111 to this chapter, Azuma discusses that speaking directly and sharply is considered arrogant and rude in Japanese culture.
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124. See note 33 to this chapter; and the first reference in note 82 to this chapter.
125. See the first reference in note 82 to this chapter, pp. 169–170.
126. Li, J. (1997). Creativity in horizontal and vertical domains. *Creativity Research Journal*, 10, 107–132.
127. This phrase came from Confucius' words from the *Analects*, providing testimony for the enduring influence of Confucius.
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129. See note 5 to Chapter 2, p. 75.
130. See the first reference in note 123 to this chapter, pp. 134–135.
131. See note 10 to this chapter.
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138. See the third reference in note 29 to Chapter 3.
139. See the fifth reference in note 29 to Chapter 4, p. 125.
140. See the fifth reference in note 29 to Chapter 4.
141. See note 49 to this chapter.
142. Kagan, J., Kearsley, R. B., & Zelazo, P. R. (1977). The effects of infant daycare on psychological development. *Evaluation Quarterly*, 1, 109–142; and Swann, Jr., W. B., & Rentfrow, P. J. (2001). Blurtatiousness: Cognitive, behavioral, and physiological consequences of rapid responding. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 81, 1160–1175.
143. See note 89 to this chapter.